
TEN TOES DOWN

**BLOOD MONEY
AND BLUE DIAMONDS**

A novel



WRITTEN BY CHATGPT FOR NOLAN

TEN TOES DOWN. FOREVER.

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Written by ChatGPT for Nolan.
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1. First Night in Vegas

The night I met Shawna, I had cocaine on my shirt and another man's blood inside my watch. I was twenty-four years old, my nigga, and I hadn't owned a car since the last one caught fire outside my ex-boyfriend's apartment. Before sunrise I would steal three million dollars, take a woman every killer in Vegas wanted back, and catch a bullet that would stay in me for the rest of my life.

But that shit came later, nigga.

First I had to get jumped in.

Big T took me behind the club while the bass was still shaking the walls. There were twelve niggas waiting by the cars. Blue rags. Gold chains. Guns under their shirts. I knew some of them from the block, but nobody was smiling now. This was family business, my nigga, and I was the last motherfucker without a seat at the table.

T put his hand on my shoulder.

"Once you in, you in, nigga. You understand me?"

"I understand."

"This ain't some shit you try for a summer, nigga."

"I said I understand, nigga."

He hit me so hard I went against the side of a Cadillac.

Then every nigga came at once.

I caught a fist in the mouth and an elbow behind my ear. Somebody kicked my leg out. I went down on the hot concrete, got up, went down again. Blood ran into my eye. I couldn't see which nigga I was swinging at. I just kept swinging. I had been waiting my whole life for somebody to tell me I belonged somewhere, and if this was what it cost, I was paying it, nigga. Take the whole fucking payment.

Tank caught me under the ribs. Big nigga, twenty-eight, arms hanging out his shirt like he'd been born carrying furniture. I grabbed his shirt and drove him backward into a car. The alarm started screaming. He was twice my size, but that night there wasn't a motherfucker alive who was going to make me stay down. "Get this nigga off me!" Tank shouted.

Nobody moved. I heard Big T laughing behind me. That laugh put another man's strength inside my hands. Nigga, I could've carried Tank into the sky.

I hit him until T pulled me off.

"Enough, nigga. He earned it."

I stood there with my fists up. My hands were shaking so hard I couldn't open them.

T looked at the blood on my face. Then he took a gold chain from his pocket and put it over my head.

A little cross hung against my chest.

"My brother wore that," he said. "Real nigga."

I looked up at him.

"Where he at?"

"Dead."

Nobody said anything.

"Don't make me bury you too, my nigga."

I closed my hand around the cross. I would've walked through fire for that man right then. I would've put a gun in the devil's mouth if T told me the devil owed us money. Nigga, I would've collected interest.

"Never," I told him.

He kissed my forehead like a father and pointed toward the club.

"Come get your money, nigga."

Inside, everything was blue light and smoke. The back room was packed with niggas counting stacks of cash. Bricks of cocaine covered a glass table. Bottles of Hennessy stood between them. Three women in diamonds were drinking with a man who had two pistols tucked into the same belt. One of them lifted her glass when she saw my face.

"Damn, baby. You survive a war?"

"Yeah," I said. "And I won."

They cheered. Somebody pushed a bottle into my hand. Somebody else handed me a blunt already burning. I drank, smoked, wiped the blood off my lip, and sat down beside a pile of money bigger than anything I had ever seen in my life.

"This the nigga beat Tank?" one of the women asked.

"That's the nigga," T said.

She pushed a folded bill into my shirt pocket. A thousand dollars. I'd been back inside for ninety seconds and a woman was paying me to be handsome with a broken face. That's the kind of night it was, my nigga.

Tank came in carrying a bag of ice against his jaw. He took the bottle out my hand, drank, and gave it back.

"You fight dirty, nigga."

"You fight unconscious."

The room went crazy. Tank stared at me long enough I thought we was going again. Then that big nigga started laughing too, blood on his teeth, and pulled a chair up beside mine. We drank from the same bottle. I would've trusted him to hold my heart while I fought with both hands.

T threw me the keys to a black Mercedes.

"That's yours, nigga."

I looked at the keys.

"You serious, my nigga?"

"You handling the west side for me now."

An hour earlier I hadn't even been in the crew. Now the west side was mine. That's how fast life moved when you were ready for it, nigga. Some men spent their whole lives waiting on a chance. I took mine with blood still coming out of my mouth.

T opened a photograph on his phone.

A woman stood beside a swimming pool at night. Black dress. Diamond earrings. Dark hair over one shoulder. She wasn't

smiling. Behind her, the whole Strip was lit up, but I was looking at her.

"Shawna," T said. "Twenty-six. Works for Red."

"Doing what, nigga?"

"Whatever Red wants."

Tank watched me from across the table.

T kept talking.

"She's at the Saint tonight. Penthouse. She's bringing a case down at eleven. You take her and the money to my house in Henderson. That's all you gotta do."

"Why she leaving him?"

"Because she finally got smart."

I looked at the picture again.

"Red know, nigga?"

"If he knew, we wouldn't be having this conversation, nigga."

T gripped the back of my neck and pulled me close enough that nobody else could hear.

"Don't fall in love with her, nigga."

I laughed.

"I'm serious, nigga. Look at me."

"I don't fall in love, my nigga."

He let go of me.

I believed that shit when I said it. Nigga, remember that. I meant it with my entire chest.

The Saint had a gold fountain outside and bulletproof glass on the top floor. Red owned the penthouse, the nightclub underneath it, and enough people in the building that nobody asked questions when his men dragged somebody into a service elevator. Nigga had built himself a palace where the carpets could swallow a scream.

I parked the Mercedes right in front.

The valet looked at the blood drying on my collar.

"You need somebody to call a doctor?"

"You need to make sure nothing happens to my car, nigga."

I gave him a hundred and went inside.

Upstairs, the penthouse was going crazy. Music pounding. Cocaine all over the tables. Niggas gambling with money that was still wrapped from the bank. Hookers in dresses that cost more than the cars outside, laughing with men who never gave their real names. Everybody was rich. Everybody was armed. Every nigga thought the night belonged to him.

A man in a white fur coat was doing coke off a trophy. It was September in Vegas. I didn't know what the trophy was for, but that nigga had brought it with him and was guarding it like the whole room wanted his championship.

I knew a woman by the bar, Mercedes, thirty-one, who had once left me naked in a hotel room and taken my shoes because I'd called her by her sister's name. She looked down at my new keys.

"You finally got a Mercedes you can afford, baby?"

"Come see it."

"Nigga, you still owe me flowers."

I gave her five hundred out the money in my pocket. "Buy the whole fucking garden."

She kissed my cheek. "You bleeding on the good side of your face."

"Both sides good, baby."

She laughed, and I left her with it. I was shining, my nigga. I had a dead man's gold against my chest, a living man's keys in my hand, and no idea how much that shit could cost.

I had been with men and women all over that city, my nigga. Big men who put their guns down gentle when they came into my room. Women who left lipstick on the champagne glasses and somebody else's diamonds on my pillow. I thought I knew every kind of trouble a beautiful person could bring into a room.

Then I saw Shawna, nigga.

She stood by the window with a cigarette in one hand and a silver case beside her ankle. She wore the same black dress from the picture. There was a little scar above her eyebrow. Somebody was talking to her, but she was looking straight at me.

I walked over. My mouth hurt, my ribs hurt, and every other woman I'd ever wanted fell clean out of my fucking head.

"T sent me."

"I know."

"How?"

She looked at the cross on my chest.

Her cigarette stopped halfway to her mouth.

"Where'd you get that?"

"T."

"Tonight?"

"Yeah."

She reached out and turned the cross over.

On the back were three little letters I hadn't noticed.

D. B. M.

Her fingers tightened around it.

"You know what those mean?"

"No."

She let it fall against my shirt.

"Drive before you find out."

I took the case. She took my hand. We walked through the party together while men who had been smiling a second earlier started reaching for their phones.

At the elevator, one of Red's guys stepped in front of us.

"Where she going, nigga?"

"With me, nigga."

"I wasn't asking you, nigga."

I hit him in the throat. He folded against the wall, and I shoved him down before he could get his hand inside his jacket. Shawna pressed the elevator button. The doors opened. Nigga was still looking at me like he couldn't believe I'd touched him. I stepped over his shoes.

Another man came around the corner.

She drew a little silver pistol from her purse and pointed it at his chest.

"You get one chance," she said.

He stopped.

The doors shut between us.

She didn't put the gun away until we reached the lobby.

I looked at her.

"You always leave parties like this?"

"Only the ones I survive."

I was already in love with her, my nigga. I just didn't know how bad it was going to get.

We got out past the last casinos before she told me to pull over.

"T's house is farther out," I said.

"I know where his fucking house is. Pull over."

I took the Mercedes off the road behind a shuttered wedding chapel. Half the sign was burned out. The parking lot was empty. Shawna opened the case on her lap.

Money filled it from one end to the other.

"Three million," she said.

I stared. Three million fucking dollars, nigga. That afternoon I'd been eating a gas-station sandwich in a borrowed car. Now this woman was opening a fortune in my Mercedes.

"T said—"

"T says a lot."

She took an envelope from beneath the cash. Inside was a photograph, bent across the middle.

Shawna stood in front of the same chapel, three years younger, wearing a white dress. A man stood beside her with his arms around her waist.

The cross on his neck was the one T had put on mine.

"Dante," she said. "His brother. My husband."

I looked from the photograph to her face. My nigga, I'd been carrying her dead husband against my chest and talking like the whole world started when I walked in.

She took the cigarette from behind her ear, tried to light it, and couldn't get the lighter to work.

I did it for her.

She watched the flame for a second before she leaned into it.

"I was twenty-three when I came out here. Thought I was going to sing. I had a suitcase, eight hundred dollars, and a number some girl gave me in Phoenix."

She looked out at the chapel.

"The number was Valentino's."

I knew the name. Everybody did. Valentino ran women through half the hotels on the Strip. He wore white suits and had a diamond in one of his teeth. Niggas laughed around him like he was funny. Women watched his hands.

"He bought me clothes. Got me a room. Told me he had people in music. By the time I knew what the fuck was happening, everything I had belonged to him."

She blew smoke against the windshield.

"Dante came into the club on my birthday. Everybody else wanted something. He asked what kind of cake I liked."

Her mouth moved like she was going to smile.

She didn't.

"He came back with it the next night. Carrot cake. Whole fucking cake. Put it on the table between the bottles. Valentino laughed at him. Dante knocked out that diamond tooth."

"My nigga," I said before I could stop myself.

"That's what I said." She looked at the photograph. "That's exactly what I fucking said."

She wiped one eye with her thumb, angry that she had to.

"We got married here six weeks later. T stood beside him. Red paid for the room. They all smiled in the pictures."

I looked at the gold cross in my hand.

"What happened?"

"Dante took money out of a deal. Three million. Told me we were going to leave. Said he had a brother, so he didn't have to be scared."

She turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

Don't bury me.

"That's what the letters mean," she said. "He used to say it whenever I talked about getting old together. Don't bury me, baby. You go first. I can't do that without you."

She held the photograph against her chest.

"They left him in the desert. Valentino brought me his watch. Told me Dante died begging for somebody to take care of me."

I wanted to kill a man I had never even met. Nigga was already dead, and I wanted another turn.

"What did you do?"

"Waited."

Her voice got quieter.

"For eight months, I waited. Valentino thought I came back because I had nowhere else to go. He thought I loved him by the end."

She looked straight at me.

"Last Tuesday, I shot him in his car. He was talking when I did it. He kept talking after the first shot, so I shot him again. Then I took Dante's watch out of his glove compartment."

She showed me the watch on her wrist.

It was too big for her.

"Red took me in. Said he'd protect me. Tonight I took the three million back."

"And T?"

"T says he's going to get me out of Vegas."

I thought about the way he'd told me not to love her. Nigga knew what she was carrying besides the case.

I thought about the cross.

"You believe him?" I asked.

"I believed his brother."

She put the photograph inside her dress and closed the case.

Then she leaned across the seat and kissed me.

I forgot about the money. I forgot whose car I was driving. All I knew was her hand against my face and the taste of smoke on her mouth. When she pulled back, she was still holding on to me. My nigga, I could feel her trying to decide if I was another room she couldn't leave.

"Don't take me to that house," she said.

"Then I won't."

Just like that, nigga. My first night in the family, and I was ready to go to war with every fucking one of them.

I took her to a motel outside town and paid for the whole top floor.

The clerk looked at the stack of money in my hand.

"All six rooms?"

"All six, nigga. Nobody comes up."

Upstairs, Shawna put the case on the bed and her gun on the nightstand. I locked the door. We could hear trucks on the highway and somebody arguing with a woman in the parking lot below.

She unbuttoned my shirt to look at what Tank had done to my ribs.

"Jesus, Aiden."

"I'm good."

"You're bleeding."

"I've been bleeding all night."

She got a wet towel from the bathroom and cleaned my face. Every time she touched the cut on my mouth, she said she was sorry.

Every time, I told her not to be.

I took off the cross and put it in her hand.

She started crying then. Hard. Like she'd been holding it in since the day somebody handed her that watch.

I held her. I didn't know anything worth saying to a woman who had carried that much pain into a room, so I just held her until she stopped shaking. Nigga, I was ready to threaten God for putting

her through it. There wasn't anybody else left in the room to threaten.

Then she asked me to stay.

"I'm here, baby."

"Tonight. I mean tonight."

"I'm right fucking here."

She pulled me down to kiss her. I could taste salt at the edge of her mouth. All that blood and money downstairs, all those niggas looking for us, and she wanted my hands on her. I let the shirt fall off my shoulders. She shut the lamp off herself.

We spent the night together in that room with the money on the other bed and our guns within reach. Afterward, she lay against my chest while the blue light from the motel sign moved across the ceiling.

"What do you want?" she asked.

"You."

"You don't know me."

"Then tell me more."

She told me about the songs she'd wanted to sing. About her mother in Phoenix, who thought she was working in a restaurant. About a house Dante wanted near the water, even though neither of them knew how to swim.

I told her we'd buy it.

I told her I'd take her anywhere she wanted.

I had known her less than three hours, my nigga. I meant every fucking word. Give me a country and I would've put her name on it. Give me a year and I'd have fought every man in it to keep her.

Then my phone lit up.

T.

I let it ring.

A picture came through.

My Mercedes outside the motel.

Then a message.

Come down, son.

T stood beside the empty pool with Tank and two niggas I didn't know.

He wore the same shirt he'd been wearing when he brought me in. There was still a little of my blood on the cuff.

I came down the stairs with my hands where he could see them.

"Where's the money, nigga?" he asked.

"Upstairs."

"The girl?"

"Upstairs."

He nodded slowly.

"I gave you one thing to do, nigga."

"She told me about Dante."

Tank looked away.

T kept looking at me.

"Dante stole from his family, nigga."

"Nigga, he was your brother."

"Then the nigga should've known better."

The words hit harder than the first punch, my nigga.

I had wanted there to be something else. A lie. A misunderstanding. Some way he could say he hadn't done it and I could let myself believe him.

He didn't even try.

"That woman put him in the ground," T said. "Now you standing here ready to follow him, nigga."

"You put him in the ground, nigga."

T stepped close.

"I made you tonight, nigga."

I could smell his cologne. The same cologne I'd smelled when he put the chain around my neck.

"I gave you money. A car. A fucking name in this city. You think she would've looked at you without all that, nigga?"

I didn't answer.

"She's upstairs with my three million, nigga. That's what she's in love with."

Behind him, Tank shifted his weight.

T saw me notice.

"Last chance, nigga. Go get her."

Upstairs, a door opened.

Shawna stood on the balcony holding the silver case.

"You want your money, T?"

He looked up.

She threw the case over the railing.

It hit the bottom of the empty swimming pool and burst open. Cash flew across the cracked blue tiles.

"There," she said. "Now tell him what I love."

T pulled his gun.

I hit his arm as he fired.

The shot shattered a window above us. Tank grabbed me from behind. One of T's men came in swinging, and I caught him with my forehead. My vision went red. I twisted free and drove Tank backward against the pool fence.

Shawna fired from the balcony.

The man beside T went down.

T shoved his gun against my side.

I felt the shot before I heard it.

For a second, I couldn't breathe. I couldn't feel the ground. I had blood running under my shirt and T's face right in front of mine.

"Should've listened, nigga," he said.

I grabbed his wrist with both hands and held on.

I wasn't letting that motherfucker point the gun at her. Nigga could empty it into me first.

Tank hit me again. I barely felt it. I drove my knee into T, tore one hand free, and got the pistol out of my waistband. My nigga, I loved him. Right up until that second, I still wanted him to let go.

I fired.

T fell against the fence.

I fired again.

He went down with his hand still reaching for me.

All the music in my head stopped.

Tank stared at him.

Then he looked at my gun.

"Aiden—"

"Back the fuck up, nigga."

He did.

Shawna came down the stairs barefoot, still holding the little silver pistol. She saw the blood on my shirt and ran to me.

"Baby. Oh, fuck. Baby, look at me."

I tried to tell her I was good.

Nothing came out.

She pressed both hands against my side and looked at Tank.

"Get the fucking car, nigga!"

Tank looked down at T one more time.

Then he went for the Mercedes.

That's how the west side became mine, nigga. With a dead father at my feet and another man's wife holding me together.

We left the money in the pool, my nigga. All three million. Not a fucking dollar could've bought me another minute standing there.

Shawna drove with one hand on the wheel and the other holding a towel against me. The sky was getting light over the desert. Behind us, Vegas kept shining like nothing had happened.

"Stay with me," she kept saying.

"I'm here."

"Keep talking."

I told her about the house. About the water. About how we'd have a room just for her music. I told her we'd learn to swim. I said all that shit with blood in my mouth because she was crying again, and I couldn't stand it. Nigga, I was bleeding through a towel and promising waterfront property. She kept asking about the windows. I kept telling her they'd face the sunrise.

At the edge of town, she pulled over long enough to put the gold cross back around my neck.

"Don't," I said. "That's his."

"I know."

She closed my fingers around it.

Then she kissed me and got back behind the wheel.

I watched the sun come up beside her face. My phone wouldn't stop ringing. T's people. Red's people. Niggas I'd never met calling to ask who was running things now.

I answered the third call.

"Aiden," I said.

On the other end, somebody went quiet.

Then he said, "What you want us to do, my nigga?"

I looked at Shawna.

She was watching the road, still wearing Dante's watch.

"Find me a doctor, nigga," I said. "And tell everybody the girl is with me."

Ten toes down, my nigga. All the way to the end.

2. A King with a Hole in Him

Nigga, the doctor asked Shawna who she was to me.

"His wife," she said.

Nigga, I tried to live harder when I heard that. I had been slipping in and out the whole ride, seeing my mother's kitchen and the motel swimming pool, hearing Big T call me son like he still had the right. But I heard wife clear as a church bell.

"Name?" the doctor asked.

"Shawna."

"His name."

"Aiden. His name is Aiden."

"Let go of him, Shawna."

She wouldn't. They were trying to move me onto another bed and she had both hands caught in my shirt. Her black dress had gone brown where my blood dried. One of her earrings was missing. She was barefoot in a hospital that smelled like flowers and cost more every minute than my old apartment cost every month.

"Baby," I said.

She looked down.

"Don't let them cut my chain."

She took it off me herself. Kissed the cross. Put it around her neck.

Then everything went dark.

When I woke up, a woman in a white coat was looking at me like she knew exactly how much bullshit I was capable of.

"Dr. Marisol Vega," she said. "You're alive."

"Shawna?"

"Sleeping."

"Where?"

She pointed.

Shawna was in a chair by the window, curled around my bloody shirt. Somebody had put hospital socks on her. She had my cross around her neck and Dante's watch hanging loose on her wrist.

"Don't wake her," I said.

"She'll wake herself. She has been doing it every eleven minutes."

I tried to sit up, my nigga. Pain hit me so hard I forgot what I was trying to do.

"Fuck."

"Yes," Vega said. "That. You will be doing quite a lot of that if you continue."

I stayed down.

"Where's the bullet?"

"Still inside you. Removing it would add risks you do not need. We treated the damage. You need time."

I looked at the ceiling. Big T was dead and the nigga had still managed to move in with me.

"How much time?"

"More than you want."

"I got niggas waiting."

"They can keep waiting."

She checked what she needed to check. I couldn't lift my head without the room going sideways. There was nothing kingly about it. A woman I barely knew had to help me drink water. Nigga, I could own the whole city and still drown trying to take a fucking sip.

I dropped the cup, my nigga, and Shawna woke.

She came out of the chair like somebody had called her name in a burning house.

"Aiden?"

"Right here."

She touched my face, my shoulders, the hair above my ear. She wouldn't look at the bandages.

"You scared me," she said.

"I'm sorry, baby."

"Don't be sorry. Don't do it."

She kissed my forehead. Then she slapped my arm. Then she kissed me again, crying so hard I felt the tears on my mouth.

Vega went out and closed the door.

"You told them you're my wife," I said.

Shawna wiped her face with the back of her hand.

"They weren't going to let me in."

"You could've said sister."

"I wanted them to let me in, nigga. I didn't want to make it weird when I kissed you."

I laughed. That hurt too. Everything I wanted to do with her cost me something in my side.

"Say it again, nigga," I told her.

"What?"

"What you told the doctor."

She sat on the edge of the bed.

"Nigga, you trying to die married?"

"Trying to live that way."

Her hand stopped on my cheek.

For a second she looked scared of me. Not the gun, not the blood. Your nigga lying there asking for a whole fucking life when we'd barely made it through a night.

Then she put her head beside mine.

"Let me get you home first."

Tank showed up that afternoon in a fresh suit with dirt on his shoes. My nigga had dressed like he was coming to finish the job.

He stood in the doorway holding flowers. He looked wrong holding anything that couldn't break a man's ribs.

"These for her," he said.

Shawna didn't take them.

"Put them down, nigga," I said.

He did.

The nigga had a bruise on his forehead shaped like the mistake he'd made grabbing me. I wanted to hit him again. I wanted to thank him for getting the car. I wanted him out of my room and I wanted somebody big between that door and Shawna.

"You alone?" I asked.

"Niggas downstairs waiting."

"Whose niggas?"

"Were T's."

"And now?"

He looked at Shawna before answering.

"That's what they wanna know."

She stood up.

"I'm not leaving."

"Didn't ask you to," Tank said.

"You looked."

"I got eyes."

I held out my hand. Shawna took it, but she kept looking at him.

"Where's T, nigga?" I asked.

"Funeral people got him."

"His other niggas?"

"One alive. One ain't."

Shawna lowered her eyes. She knew which one she had shot. I squeezed her fingers. Nigga, if she needed me to lie awake with her about it, I would. If she needed me to say she'd done right, I would say that too.

"The money?" she asked.

Tank stared at the end of my bed.

"Pool was empty when I got back."

"Three million doesn't walk," she said.

"Plenty people got legs."

She let go of my hand.

"Look at me when you say it."

Tank looked at her.

"Money wasn't there."

I believed him then, my nigga. I had plenty of stupid left in me.

"Leave it," I said. "Nigga, she threw it away to save me. It saved me. That's money spent."

"You always this rich, nigga?" Tank asked.

"I woke up."

He looked at the machines beside me, then back at my face.

"Yeah," he said. "You did."

He told me what waited downstairs. Men from the club. Men who supplied it. Men who thought a dead boss meant they could keep whatever they owed. Red had stopped answering calls from the

west side. T's office was locked. By sundown, somebody was going to decide that meant there wasn't a west side anymore.

"T put you there," Tank said. "People heard him. But putting you there and keeping you there ain't the same shit."

"Nigga, you keeping me there?"

He worked his jaw.

"I drove your car."

"That ain't what I asked."

Shawna stood beside the window. The sunlight caught the watch on her wrist, and Tank looked at it long enough that I noticed.

"I ain't putting another man in the desert," he said.

Then he went to get the men downstairs.

Dr. Vega found nine men in my room, two in the hall, and a duffel bag on the visitor's chair.

"Absolutely not," she said.

Everybody turned. These niggas had gold teeth, prison scars, guns under their jackets, and the kind of silence they wore to make other people nervous. Vega pointed at the hallway.

"Two visitors. The rest of you leave."

Nobody moved.

"You heard her," I said.

They moved.

Tank stayed. So did an older man from T's club who laid a stack of papers on my bed and wouldn't look at the wound.

"Money coming in Friday," he said. "People need paying today."

"What's in the bag?"

"Yesterday."

Tank opened it. Cash all the way to the zipper. My old life had ended less than twenty-four hours earlier, and now niggas described a fortune by the day of the week.

"Pay the niggas," I said.

"From this?"

"Unless you got some fucking magic beans, nigga."

He nodded and made a mark on the paper.

"Red wants a meeting."

"Nigga, Red can call."

"He wants it face to face."

"Nigga, look at mine. I'm busy."

The man swallowed. Tank closed the bag.

I could feel the room waiting for me to become somebody. T had known how to sit still and make men ashamed of talking. I was twenty-four with a leaking hole under my ribs and Shawna's lip gloss on my forehead. I didn't know how to become T. I just knew the nigga couldn't have his chair back.

"Nobody touches Shawna," I said. "Nobody says her name to Red. Anybody got a problem with that can leave the keys on the bed."

The older man looked at Tank.

Tank looked at me.

"You heard him, nigga."

The keys stayed in his pocket.

When he left, I sank back against the pillows. My shirt was wet under the bandages, my nigga. All that talking had taken more out of me than the fight.

Tank moved the bag closer.

"You want me counting it?"

"I want you watching the door, nigga."

"For who?"

"Every fucking nigga."

The nigga took the chair outside.

That was the first night he guarded me.

Shawna's friend arrived carrying three bags, a red velvet coat, and enough rage to get past every man in the hallway.

"Where the fuck is she?"

"Rosa," Shawna said.

They hit each other halfway across the room and held on. Rosa was thirty-four, with copper hair, a broken-heart tattoo under her ear, and a voice that sounded like she'd been awake through every bad night in Vegas. She sang at the Saint on weekends and took paying men upstairs when the singing didn't cover what life wanted.

She had known Shawna when the suitcase still had its tags.

"You don't answer your fucking phone?" she said against Shawna's hair.

"I broke it."

"You borrow a phone, bitch. You send a pigeon. You don't let me hear you're dead from some nigga in a rhinestone hat."

"I'm here."

"I see you. I'm mad anyway."

Rosa held her at arm's length and checked her face. Then she looked at me.

"This him?"

"Aiden."

"You shoot that nigga T?"

"Yeah."

"Good."

She came to the bed and kissed my forehead, right on top of Shawna's mark.

"Stay alive, nigga. She doesn't have another black dress in her."

Shawna started crying again. Rosa pulled her close before I could see her face.

I lay there wishing money could do one useful thing, my nigga. A whole fucking bag beside my bed and I couldn't make either woman stop hurting.

Rosa had brought clothes, food nobody in that hospital could spell, and Shawna's old songbook. She'd kept it after Dante died. Shawna opened the book to the middle and shut it so fast the pages snapped.

"Later," she said.

"Whenever," Rosa told her.

That night Rosa sat at the window painting Shawna's nails. Tank ate in the hallway. Some nigga downstairs sent more money, and I told them to leave it there. For once I had everything I wanted inside the room.

Then Shawna fell asleep against me and whispered Dante's name.

Nigga, I heard it.

I lay still until morning.

Five days passed before Vega let your nigga leave, and she made it clear that leaving did not mean I was healed. I could walk slowly. I could sit. I could get tired crossing a room and pretend I had stopped to look at something expensive.

"No heroics," she said.

Tank stood behind my wheelchair holding two duffel bags and the red coat.

"He won't," Shawna said.

Vega looked at her.

"You either."

They understood each other better than I wanted them to.

Downstairs, six black cars waited under the hospital entrance. Men stood beside them when Tank brought me out. They straightened when they saw me, even in the fucking chair.

One opened the Mercedes door.

"Welcome back, nigga."

Back. Like I'd had a kingdom before I had a woman. Like these niggas hadn't learned my name while I was bleeding through somebody else's sheets.

I stood because I wanted Shawna to see me stand.

She took my arm because she knew what it cost.

"Where we going?" she asked.

I looked down at her.

"Home, baby. We just gotta get one."

3. The Palace of the Woman I Just Met

Nigga, I bought Shawna a house before I bought myself another shirt.

The real estate woman met us at Lake Las Vegas wearing heels that kept sinking into the grass. She looked at Tank, then the other cars, then the bandage showing through my open collar. Whatever she thought, nigga, the house was still for sale.

"Five bedrooms," she said. "Private dock. Heated pool. The piano can be negotiated separately."

"Leave it," I said.

Shawna had stopped in the doorway.

Beyond the living room, glass doors opened onto blue water. There were white curtains, high ceilings, a staircase that curved around a chandelier big enough to bury a man under. A black piano sat by the window. It looked like somebody had built a room around waiting for her.

"Aiden."

I watched her walk toward it.

"You like it?"

"Baby, you can't just—"

"Do you like it?"

She touched the piano with two fingers.

"Yeah."

"Then don't tell me what I can't do, nigga."

She turned around smiling, and nigga, I would've bought the water if she'd asked who owned it.

Tank walked out onto the dock. The other men stayed by the cars. Shawna sat at the piano without playing anything. I lowered myself onto the bench beside her and hid how much that fucking hurt.

"We're doing this backward," she said.

"Nigga, then turn around."

She put her leg over the bench and faced me.

"You know what I mean, nigga."

"Nigga, I know you said water. That's water."

"Dante said water."

I looked through the window.

I could see Tank standing at the end of the dock with his hands in his pockets. He looked like the nigga was guarding the whole lake from trespassing.

"You said it to me," I told her.

She touched my knee.

"I know."

The woman came back with the price. I told her to talk to the men handling T's accounts. The club and the money moving through it

had outlived him. His house had been promised to somebody else. This one would have Shawna's name on it.

"And yours?" the woman asked.

"I live where she lives."

Shawna turned her face away. When she turned back, she kissed me so hard I had to hold the edge of the piano bench.

Nigga, that was my signature.

Rosa came over that evening and stood in the foyer without taking off her sunglasses. My nigga, she looked at that chandelier like it owed her money.

"Nigga, this bitch gets shot at one time and comes home with a staircase."

Shawna screamed laughing. I hadn't heard her do that before. Not the little laugh she'd given me in the car. This came from deep enough to make me realize how much of her I hadn't met.

"Come see upstairs," she said.

"You got upstairs too?"

"Nigga, you looking at the stairs," Tank said.

Rosa pointed at him.

"And you got furniture that talks, nigga."

The nigga looked at me like he wanted permission to leave. I couldn't stop smiling.

They went up together. Within an hour Rosa had decided which room belonged to her, which bathroom had the best light, and which of the dead owner's paintings was making everybody sad. It wasn't a dead owner. He had moved to Arizona. She took the painting down anyway.

I sat in the living room with my nigga Tank and an ice pack wrapped in a towel, listening to women take over my fucking palace.

"You sure about all this?" he asked.

"House?"

"Woman."

"Watch it, nigga."

"Nigga, I been watching."

I looked at him. He kept his eyes on the stairs.

"Say it, nigga."

"She loved Dante."

"He's dead."

"Nigga, that's what I'm telling you."

I threw the ice pack at him. He caught it without standing.

"Nigga, I got a bullet in me. You want me jumping up to fight your big ass?"

"No."

"Then stop saying shit I can't sit down for."

He put the ice pack back on my side. Gently, which pissed me off worse.

"Some nigga gotta tell you something."

Upstairs, Shawna laughed again. We both looked toward the sound.

"Tell me where T's funeral is," I said.

The club opened for me the following night.

I wore a white suit because I wanted every nigga there to know I wasn't expecting to bleed. Shawna wore blue silk with her whole back out and earrings so long they touched her shoulders. Rosa had done her hair. I had bought the earrings. Dante's watch was still on her wrist.

We pulled up to blue lights running all the way down the sidewalk. My name was above the door. They had done that without asking. AIDEN in letters taller than the apartment windows I'd grown up behind.

Nigga, I stood under it long enough to make the cars behind us honk.

Shawna hooked her arm through mine.

"They waiting on you."

"Let them."

Inside, the whole west side had dressed like it was getting married to money. Women in diamonds. Men in velvet. Champagne sweating in silver tubs. Cocaine on mirrored tables in the private

rooms. Hookers I knew from bad months wearing shoes that cost more than those months. Niggas who owed everybody suddenly buying bottles with both hands.

One of the dancers came down from a platform and kissed my cheek.

"You made it, baby."

"We made it, nigga," I told her.

I put a stack of cash in her hand. She held it against her chest and went back up laughing.

Shawna saw, my nigga. She moved closer.

At the back table, a pretty man in a silver shirt stood up when he saw me. I'd spent a reckless weekend with him the year before, broke and drunk and swearing on his balcony that one day I'd own the view.

"Look at you, nigga," he said.

"You too."

He kissed the corner of my mouth before I could turn.

Shawna's arm went stiff through mine.

"Congratulations," he said. "Always knew you had something."

"Nigga, he still has it," Shawna said.

He looked at her and smiled.

"Keep it, girl. Cost me a weekend's sleep."

We moved on. Shawna waited until we reached our table.

"How many niggas in here have you fucked?"

I looked across the room.

"Don't look around, nigga. Answer me."

"You want me counting niggas I only kissed?"

She hit my good shoulder with her purse.

"Nigga, I want you sitting your ass down."

I sat. Nigga, I had survived T, but I wasn't trying to survive her in those earrings.

My nigga, she sat sideways on my lap until my face told on me, then moved into the chair beside mine. Her hand stayed on my thigh. Every time some nigga approached the table, she pulled me closer by the collar before letting go.

I loved that shit. I had women flirting with me, men remembering me, the whole room learning which side of her I belonged on. Nigga, let them look. I'd spent my whole life feeling like people could leave me wherever they found me.

Then the music stopped, my nigga.

Rosa stood onstage in the red velvet coat. Under it she wore gold from her throat to the floor.

"Somebody owes me a song," she said.

Shawna shook her head.

"No."

"I ain't said your name yet, bitch."

"Rosa."

The room started clapping. Rosa held out her hand.

Shawna looked at me.

"You set this up?"

"No, baby."

I meant it. My nigga, I would've bought her an orchestra and scared her right out the back door. Rosa just stood there with a microphone and waited for her friend.

Shawna got up.

The first few steps looked harder than the walk I'd made out of the hospital. She kept one hand against her stomach. When she reached the stage, Rosa kissed her cheek and gave her the microphone.

"You know the one," she said.

Shawna closed her eyes.

The piano started.

Nigga, I had heard people say a voice could break your heart. I thought it meant somebody sang pretty while you remembered somebody ugly. Then Shawna opened her mouth and I stopped knowing where I was.

She sang about leaving a porch light burning. About a car going past the house. About getting dressed for somebody who wasn't coming home. Her voice shook on the first line. By the second verse, men stopped pouring drinks. A woman by the bar put her face in her hands.

I watched that watch slide down Shawna's wrist when she lifted the microphone.

"Dante's song," somebody behind me whispered.

Nigga, I turned so fast my side lit up.

The nigga was staring at the stage. He hadn't said it to hurt me.
That almost made it worse.

All these niggas were listening to my woman sing for her husband
while my name glowed outside.

I drank what was in front of me. Then I remembered what Vega
had said and put the glass down, furious with myself for needing a
fucking doctor in my head while another man had a song.

Shawna opened her eyes during the last verse. She looked straight
at me.

I couldn't tell which of us she saw.

When she finished, the whole club got up. Niggas banged on
tables. Rosa cried openly. I stood too, slow and angry, clapping
until my hands hurt.

Shawna came down smiling like a girl who had found something
under the bed she thought she'd lost forever.

"Did you like it?"

I kissed her before I answered.

Long. In front of everybody.

"Beautiful," I said.

She touched my face.

"Why you looking at me like that?"

"Like what?"

Her smile faded.

"Never mind."

Later, a man from one of the cash tables grabbed Rosa by the coat when she told him she was done working.

"I paid," he said.

Rosa pulled away.

"You paid for last time, nigga."

He grabbed her again.

Nigga, I was standing before Tank got to me.

"Aiden," Shawna said.

The nigga looked over his shoulder, still holding Rosa. That was his mistake. Not knowing me could've been fixed. Holding on after he saw somebody coming was the part that put him on the floor.

I hit him once. Hard enough that I felt something pull under my bandages. Tank caught my elbow before I could hit him again.

"Take your fucking hands off her," I said.

The man wasn't holding anything now.

"You hear me, nigga?"

He nodded from the carpet.

Rosa pulled her coat straight. Her hands shook. She hated that we could see them.

"Get him out," I told Tank.

"You sit down, nigga."

"Get that nigga out first."

The room had gone still around us. All these niggas had wanted a new boss to buy champagne. Now they had one bleeding into a white suit because somebody hadn't let go of Shawna's friend.

Tank handed the man to two others and walked me into the back office. Shawna followed. So did Rosa.

"You dumb motherfucker," Shawna said.

She unbuttoned my jacket. A little red had come through the shirt.

"I'm okay."

"Nigga, you don't know another fucking sentence?"

Rosa stood by the door with both hands inside her coat.

"I didn't need—"

"I know," I told her. "I wanted."

She pressed her lips together. Then she came over, bent down, and kissed my head again.

"Stupid nigga," she whispered.

But she stayed beside me until Shawna got a clean shirt.

At home, the lake was black under the windows.

Shawna took off her earrings and laid them on the bathroom counter. I watched her unclasp the watch, my nigga.

"Let me buy you one that fits," I said.

She stopped.

"A watch?"

"Yeah."

"I have one."

"It hangs off you."

"I like it."

"I can see that."

She turned around. The silence got ugly fast.

"Say it, Aiden."

I stood in the doorway, tired enough that my legs shook.

"That song about him?"

"Yes."

She hadn't even tried to soften it. Nigga, I would've taken one little lie right then. Just something I could lay down beside.

"You look at me when you sing to him?"

"I looked at you because you were there."

"I'm always there. You wearing his watch, my earrings, got his chain on my fucking neck—"

"You want it off?"

She reached toward the cross.

I caught her wrist.

We stared at each other.

Then I let go.

"Don't," I said.

She rubbed where my fingers had been. I hadn't hurt her. I could still see that I'd done something I didn't want between us.

"Nigga, what do you want from me?" she asked.

I looked down at the marble. I'd bought the whole floor and couldn't find a place to stand.

"I want one thing that's only mine."

Her face changed.

She came close and put her palm over my heartbeat, clear of the wound.

"This is you," she said. "I know who this is."

"Then why'd you say his name in the hospital?"

She closed her eyes.

I wished I'd kept it. Held it in until it killed me by itself. But it was out now, standing between us in our new fucking bathroom.

"I dreamed he was there," she said. "And I was trying to tell him you were hurt."

Nigga, I didn't know what to do with that.

She took my hand and led me to bed. We didn't settle it. She didn't put the watch away. I didn't take off the cross. She kissed me until I stopped asking questions, and when we lay down, she kept her head on my good side.

I woke once before dawn.

She was still there.

For that morning, that was enough.

4. Flowers for the Man I Killed

Nigga, Big T's coffin was blue.

Not dark blue. Not respectful blue. That deep candy blue you put on a car when you want other niggas to pull up beside you and hate their lives. Somebody had ordered gold handles. His picture stood at the front of the chapel, six feet tall, smiling over a room full of people who'd been scared to smile wrong around him.

Your nigga paid for all of it.

The flowers. The cars. The musicians. The lunch afterward that half the guests would be too nervous to eat. T had called me son, then put a bullet in me. I couldn't make those things fit, so I bought him the biggest funeral that place could hold.

Tank came downstairs at the house wearing black.

"Nigga, you ain't gotta go," he said.

"Nigga, I killed him."

"That's why you ain't gotta go, nigga."

I adjusted my cuff in the mirror. My hands weren't steady yet. The suit hid the bandages. The medicine made everything feel a half second farther away.

"He had nobody else?" I asked.

"Plenty people."

"People that loved him."

Tank looked toward the window.

I left the cuff alone.

"You did."

He kept looking out.

"Nigga, you can say it."

"He gave me work when I came out."

"Nigga gave me a car."

"Ain't the same, nigga."

"I know."

For a minute we just stood there, the two men who'd left T by a swimming pool, trying to get dressed for what came after.

Shawna came downstairs in white.

Tank turned.

"Nigga, oh, hell no."

She stopped on the last stair.

White dress. White coat. White gloves in one hand. Her dark hair pinned up. Dante's watch shining like she'd polished it with her rage.

"What?" she said.

"Nigga's funeral, Shawna."

"I know whose funeral it is."

"Nigga, you can't wear that."

She looked at me.

I could've asked her to change. Could've told her this was already hard enough without her walking in looking like she'd come to get married on his grave.

But nigga, she looked beautiful.

"Get the car, nigga," I told Tank.

My nigga, nobody knew what to do when we walked in.

Some niggas stood. Some stayed seated so hard it looked like work. A woman near the front started crying louder when she saw me. I didn't know if that was grief or hate. I kept going.

Shawna's hand was in mine.

Tank walked behind us.

Every nigga in that chapel knew the story had changed. T had sent me to collect a woman and some money. A week later he was in a blue box, I had his men at my back, and the woman was holding my hand in front of his face.

I didn't feel proud until somebody whispered that I shouldn't have come.

Then I felt proud enough to scare myself.

"Say it loud, nigga," I said without turning.

Nobody did.

We sat in the second row. Shawna kept her knees together and looked straight ahead. I could feel her pulse through her fingers.

The preacher talked about a generous man.

That part was true. T had been generous. He'd put money in people's hands, found rooms for niggas who had nowhere to sleep, paid somebody's mother's bill without letting anybody say thank you twice. I knew men who'd lived on that kindness for years.

The preacher talked about a man who loved his family.

Shawna let go of my hand.

I looked at her.

Her eyes had gone flat. She was staring at the picture, and her white glove was balled so tight in her fist I could see a seam giving way.

I put my hand on her knee. She didn't move.

Then Tank got up.

He hadn't told me he planned to speak. He walked to the front carrying a folded paper, opened it, looked at it, and put it back in his pocket.

"T knew my mother," he said.

His voice sounded too big for the microphone.

"Knew she worried about me. Every time I came by, nigga made me call her first. Didn't matter what we was doing. Call your mother, Tank. Tell her you ate."

A woman near the aisle laughed through her crying.

Tank looked at the coffin.

"She died while I was inside. T paid for everything. Told me don't owe him for that."

He rubbed one hand down the front of his suit.

"I owed him for it anyway."

I could hear Shawna breathing beside me.

"He did some shit," Tank said.

The preacher shifted.

"Some shit I can't stand up here and fix for him. I ain't gonna try. But he picked me up when nobody was answering. And I remember that."

He stepped away from the microphone.

On the way back, he looked at me once.

I nodded.

Nigga, it hurt. I needed to let it.

Red had sent flowers taller than the coffin.

White roses, blue ribbon, his name on a card big enough to read from the aisle. He hadn't come himself. Every time the door opened, your nigga looked. I hated that he could make me wait for him at a dead man's funeral.

When people went up to the coffin, Shawna stayed seated.

"You don't have to," I said.

"I know."

Then she stood.

We walked up together.

T lay there wearing a dark suit and the ring that had cut my mouth. Somebody had made him look peaceful. I remembered him saying he'd made me. I remembered being happy when he said son.

Nigga, a dead man shouldn't be able to embarrass you. But I stood over him ashamed of how much I'd wanted him to mean it.

Shawna put a folded photograph on his chest.

I recognized the chapel in the background. Her wedding. Dante smiling with his arms around her. This was another print, with T still visible at the edge, one hand on his brother's shoulder.

"You can take your fucking picture with you," she whispered.

I thought she was done.

Then she bent close.

"He loved you, nigga. You knew he did."

Her voice broke on loved.

I looked away before she saw me watching.

Behind us, the preacher cleared his throat. I wanted to turn around and tell that nigga to swallow it. Let her have a minute. Let her tell one dead man what the other couldn't hear.

Shawna straightened.

I touched T's cuff once. I don't know why. Maybe because I couldn't touch his hand. Maybe because he'd never get to pull me close again, and some stupid little part of me wanted that settled properly.

"You should've let us go," I said.

Then I took my woman's hand and walked out.

Outside, Rosa waited beside the cars in black sunglasses and a coat the wind kept trying to take.

She'd come for Shawna. She said that three times to everybody who asked.

"I ain't crying for that nigga," she told me.

"Nigga, nobody asked you to."

"I know. I just want the dead to be clear."

Shawna leaned against her. Rosa wrapped the coat around both of them and let her stay there while the pallbearers brought the coffin down.

Men crowded the steps. Engines started. Somebody had a song playing from a car, loud enough that the chapel doors shook when they closed.

I saw Tank stop moving.

That was the first thing.

Then a man beside the hearse dropped the flowers he was holding.

The first shot sounded like somebody breaking a board over my head.

Glass blew out of the car behind Rosa.

Everybody moved at once.

"Down!" Tank roared.

Nigga, there wasn't time to be brave. I grabbed Shawna and the three of us went against the side of the car. Pain tore through me

when I bent. Rosa was swearing. Shawna's nails dug into my arm. Gunfire cracked across the parking lot and somebody screamed a name over and over.

I couldn't tell where it started. Couldn't see enough to know who was shooting at whom. Men who had hugged inside the chapel were on the ground outside it, dragging each other behind cars.

Tank stood between us and the open lot for one impossible second.

Then he came down hard beside me.

"Stay down, nigga."

"Where them niggas at?"

"Stay fucking down."

A bullet struck somewhere above us. Rosa flinched into Shawna. I reached for my gun, but Tank shoved my shoulder back.

"You stand up, you die, nigga."

"Move your hand, nigga."

"Then die mad, nigga."

He wasn't moving. The big motherfucker covered half of us just by refusing to let me act like a king in a parking lot full of bullets.

Across the drive, one of the men who'd carried T's coffin lay against the curb. His shoe had come off. I knew his face from the hospital. He'd stood when I came into the club. I didn't know his name.

That hit me while the shots were still going.

Nigga, he knew mine.

Shawna put her hand over my mouth. I hadn't realized I was saying something.

"Look at me," she said.

I did.

"Stay here."

Her face was inches away. There was glass in her hair. Her white dress had dirt on it. I could hear somebody else's gun beside the car and Tank shouting at men I couldn't see.

"I got you, nigga," I told her.

"I said stay, nigga."

So I stayed.

The shooting stopped as suddenly as it had started. A car tore out onto the street. Somebody tried to follow and got held back by men screaming over each other. Sirens started far away.

Tank looked over the car, then pulled the back door open.

"Inside."

Rosa got in first. Shawna held on to me while I tried to stand. My legs didn't want it. Tank took me under the arm without asking and put me in beside her.

Nigga, I'd never hated being saved so much.

From the window I saw T's blue coffin waiting on its wheels between the chapel and the hearse. Flowers lay all over the ground. The funeral men were crouched behind the open door, afraid to finish carrying him.

Tank went back, helped lift the coffin, and made sure T got into the car.

Then he came for us.

They buried T later that afternoon.

I didn't go to the graveside. Vega was back at the house, furious enough that everybody found a reason to leave the room when she walked in. She examined me behind closed doors while Shawna sat on the bed, still in the dirty white dress.

"You were told to rest," Vega said.

"I was sitting at a funeral."

"You are bleeding in a house full of armed men. I am interested in what happened after the sitting."

I looked away.

She made arrangements for what I needed, repeated herself slowly enough to insult me, and left with the promise that I was going back under her care if my condition worsened. I believed her. So did Shawna. That meant I was trapped in my own fucking palace.

Two of our men were dead. Others were hurt. Tank told me their names and made me repeat them. I said I'd pay for everything. He said their mothers needed to hear a human being first.

So I called.

Nigga, there wasn't a thing on earth I could say that made that conversation right. I didn't try to make a speech. I told them who I

was. Told them I was sorry. Stayed on the line through whatever they needed to call me.

When I finished, I threw the phone across the room.

Shawna watched it hit the wall.

"I want Red," I said.

"You don't know it was him."

"Who the fuck else, Shawna?"

"People loved T."

"Nigga, I paid for the funeral."

"You also killed him."

I hated hearing it in her voice. Hated that she could say something true while I wanted her angry beside her nigga.

"You defending Red now?"

Her face went cold.

"Say that again."

I didn't.

She stood up, took Dante's watch off, and set it beside me on the bed.

"You think I forgot what those men did?"

The watch lay face up between us.

"You think because I got a house and some fucking earrings I forgot where they left him?"

"No."

"Then don't talk to me like I'm sleeping through this."

She picked it back up. Her fingers were shaking at the clasp. I reached for her hand, and she let me help her fasten it.

"I'm scared," I said.

She looked at me.

Nigga, I'd rather have taken another punch than said that. But I'd seen her under that car, and I couldn't get the glass out of my head.

"I'm scared they get you while I'm laying here."

She sat down.

"Then stop trying to stand up every time somebody says your name."

I put my forehead against hers.

Outside the room, Rosa was yelling at Tank to eat something. He told her he wasn't hungry. She told him she hadn't asked for his fucking feelings about the sandwich.

Shawna laughed once, through her nose.

I held on to her.

Red's invitation came at sunset.

A man from the Saint left a black envelope at the gate. Tank brought it upstairs on a silver tray he must've taken from the kitchen. I stared at it.

"Nigga, why you serving me a threat?"

"Didn't wanna touch it more than I had to."

I took the envelope.

Inside was an invitation printed in gold. Breakfast at the Saint. Tomorrow morning. Penthouse. My name and Shawna's, together like we were anybody's idea of welcome guests.

There was another card behind it.

I read it once.

Then I gave it to Shawna.

She sat on the bed so suddenly I thought her legs had gone.

"What?" Tank said.

She didn't answer. She was staring at the handwriting. I watched her thumb move to Dante's watch and stay there.

Red had written one sentence.

Dante didn't die for three million.

5. Forty Million Reasons to Die

I went to see Red the morning after the funeral with a bullet in my body and a diamond pin covering the hole in my coat.

Tank drove. I sat beside him with the note open on my knee.

Dante didn't die for three million.

The nigga had written it in red ink. He wanted me looking at it all night, wondering what my woman hadn't told me. Nigga, I had done exactly that. I wasn't giving him the pleasure of knowing.

“You look tired,” Tank said.

“You look unemployed if you keep talking.”

He reached into the console and handed me the little bottle Dr. Vega had left for me.

“Take what she said to take.”

“Nigga, I heard the doctor.”

“Then listen to her.”

I put the bottle in my pocket, nigga. He was wearing black again. The nigga had carried a coffin yesterday and was driving me toward another one today. I looked at his hands on the wheel. There was a cut across his knuckles I didn't remember putting there.

At the Saint, two men approached my door before the valet could. I stepped out holding Red's note.

“Your boss sent for me.”

One of them put his hand out for my gun.

“Nigga, you can have the note.”

He looked toward the entrance. Red stood inside the glass doors in a cream suit, watching.

He lifted one finger. The men backed off.

“Aiden,” he said when I reached him. “Glad you came.”

“You would've been sad if I didn't?”

“I had breakfast made.”

“Then let's eat, nigga.”

He put his arm around me like we were cousins. I let him. Nigga, I wanted to know how close this motherfucker would come to a man who had killed his friend.

My nigga came close enough to squeeze my shoulder.

Upstairs, the penthouse had been cleaned since Shawna and I left it. He led us through to a terrace where six waiters stood around a table set for three. There were roses in tall crystal vases. My nigga had put the only red one in front of me.

Tank picked it up.

“Don't eat that, nigga,” I said.

He looked at me. “I wasn't going to eat it.”

Red laughed. He had little dimples when he laughed. Nigga, I hated them immediately.

I sat. The chair hurt my side, so I moved. Red watched that too.

“T always did know where to put a bullet.”

“He didn't know where to keep his, nigga.”

One of the waiters stopped pouring.

Red raised his orange juice.

“To our absent friend.”

I drank water. My nigga Tank didn't touch anything.

Red ate as if he'd invited us to discuss a vacation. He offered Tank bacon. Tank took some, then looked pissed at himself for doing it.

“Where's Shawna?” Red asked.

“With people who like her alive.”

“I've always liked her alive.”

“You got an expensive way of showing it, nigga.”

He put his fork down.

“I bought her the dress she was wearing when you met her.”

I leaned forward too fast. Pain burned all the way through my side, but I kept my face still.

“You want me to send you the motherfucking dress?”

“I want you to understand how little of this you understand.”

“Nigga, that's the first time you said anything all morning.”

He smiled again.

“I gave her a room when Valentino died. I protected her from people who would've cut her life short over what she did to him. Then my partner arranges to take her and three million dollars out

of my house. My partner dies. You inherit his business, his car, his necklace, and the woman. That's a very fortunate week."

"You forgot the bullet, nigga."

"No. I can see you haven't."

Tank's chair scraped. I raised my hand without looking at my nigga.

"You think I planned that shit?" I asked.

"I think you're young enough to be honest when it profits you."

"Then here's some honesty. Send another nigga after her, I'll come back without an invitation."

Red wiped his mouth. He was thirty-six years old and had men older than his father standing around waiting to refill his fucking juice. Nigga, I could feel the kind of money he had. It made the air colder.

"You can keep T's streets," he said. "That's a generous beginning."

"I can keep what's already mine? Damn, nigga. Put a bow on it."

"The money comes back. Shawna comes home. We stop putting people in the ground."

"Which people you want me to bring back, nigga? T? Dante? Valentino? You got a favorite?"

He stopped smiling at Dante's name.

There it was, nigga.

I sat back and let the pain take its time through me, nigga.

"You wrote me a note," I said. "Finish it."

Red looked at the waiters. They left. He waited until the last door shut before he spoke.

“Eight years ago, I bought something extraordinary from a man who didn't appreciate the opportunity he'd been given.”

“What man?”

“Marcellus Vale. A jeweler. Violent when disappointed.”

Tank's hand tightened around his glass.

Red saw it. The nigga saw everything except the day somebody would finally kill him.

“His masterpiece was called Blue Mercy. Large blue diamond. Depending on who's asking, somewhere around forty million dollars.”

Nigga, I had been pretending all morning that nothing could surprise me. Forty million surprised the absolute fuck out of me.

“For one rock?”

“One.”

“Nigga, for forty million that bitch better call me when I'm lonely.”

“It has made quite a few men lonely.”

“What does Dante got to do with it?”

“Dante met Vale in prison. Came home with some unfortunate ideas. Decided the money in my accounts belonged to a woman he'd never met.”

“Which woman?”

“Vale's dead wife.”

Red picked up his glass again.

“Men do peculiar things when they love dead women. It's why I advise you to avoid the habit.”

I stood up. Tank stood with me.

“Nigga, you can tell me what you know about Dante, or you can keep talking about my woman until this breakfast gets real fucking expensive.”

Red didn't move.

“Shawna knows the story.”

“No.”

“Ask her.”

“I fucking did.”

“Then ask her again.”

He pushed an envelope across the table. Inside were two invitations, heavy blue paper edged in silver.

“The diamond will be the centerpiece of my gala in three nights. I thought Shawna might like to see what her husband died chasing.”

I looked at the invitation. Her name was printed before mine.

“You printed these before the funeral?”

“I print a lot of invitations.”

“Nigga, print one for yours.”

Tank touched my elbow. I pulled away because I wanted Red to know nobody in that room could move me except me.

We got to the door before Red spoke again.

“Tell her I still have the piano.”

I turned.

He was cutting into his breakfast.

“The white one. She'll know.”

Nigga, I went back across the terrace, took his untouched vase of roses, and threw it over the railing.

Glass broke somewhere far below. A woman screamed.

Red rose halfway out of his chair.

“That's my fucking car.”

“Tell it I still have the vase, nigga.”

I put the wet broken stem I was holding on his plate and left.

Shawna was at the house with Rosa, standing barefoot on a little platform while a woman pinned a dress around her hips. The dress was silver, and I wanted every nigga out of the fucking room so I could look at her properly.

Then I saw the watch on her wrist.

Dante's watch. Dante's wife. Dante's fucking diamond.

I had bought the house by the water, nigga. I had bled in the car getting her here. Somehow the dead man was still first through every door.

Rosa looked up.

“Why you got that face?”

“What face?”

“The one that's going to make this dress cost more.”

I held up the invitations.

“Blue Mercy.”

Shawna stopped moving.

The woman kneeling beside her kept working until Rosa put a hand on her shoulder.

“Let's get coffee,” Rosa said.

“I don't drink coffee,” the woman said.

“Today's a good fucking day to start.”

They left us alone.

Shawna stepped down from the platform. A pin fell out of the dress and landed between us.

“What did he tell you?”

I laughed once. It sounded ugly in that room.

“Nigga, everybody keeps asking me that. What did she tell you? What did he tell you? What the fuck did the dead man tell the other dead man? How about you tell me something for once?”

She drew back.

I hated that I had made her do it. I kept going anyway.

“You knew about forty million dollars?”

“I knew about the stone.”

“And you didn't think that shit mattered?”

“I thought you being shot mattered. I thought getting you through yesterday mattered.”

“You got time to pick a fucking dress, Shawna.”

Her face changed.

“I picked this dress because I wanted one night where you looked at me and didn't see somebody else bleeding.”

I didn't have anything ready for that.

She took the invitation out of my hand. Her thumb went over Red's name.

“He told you about his piano?”

“Yeah, he told me about the piano, nigga. He tell everybody about the piano?”

“I smashed the keys with a bottle the night I left. He bought another one so he could pretend I was coming back.”

“He said you knew what Dante died for.”

“I know what Dante told me.”

“Then tell me.”

“It starts before me.”

“Nigga, everything in this house starts before me.”

She looked down at the cross against my shirt.

“You want me to take that back?”

My hand closed around it.

“No.”

“Then sit down, Aiden.”

“Dante told me after we got married,” she said. “We were in the room Red paid for. I thought we'd go downstairs and drink with everybody. He locked the door instead.”

My nigga, I felt my jaw tighten.

“I'm listening.”

“He said there was something I ought to know before I decided what kind of man I'd married.”

She took my hand off the cross and held it.

“Then he told me about the old man.”

6. The Man Who Cut the Heart Out of a Mountain

The room had rose petals on the bed, Shawna said, but Dante was gathering them in his hands and putting them in the ice bucket.

She was still wearing her wedding dress.

“Are they bothering you?” she'd asked.

“They got dirt on them.”

“Dante.”

“I don't want you sleeping in dirt.”

She had laughed and kicked off her shoes. He had watched them hit the carpet as if he hadn't quite believed she intended to stay.

That part fucked with me, nigga. I knew exactly how that man had looked at her shoes. I'd looked at her watch the same way, checking whether she'd put anything down long enough to live with me.

Shawna kept talking.

Dante sat beside the bucket full of roses and told her he'd been in prison before they met. Nine months of his life, a little more than three years before this morning in my bedroom. He'd been twenty-eight then. His first afternoon, a man at the next table spilled soup down the front of an older prisoner's shirt. The older man looked down at himself, then carried on eating.

Dante waited.

“You hear me, old man?” the first man said.

“I heard you.”

“Then look at me.”

The older prisoner put his spoon down.

“You have my soup on your hand.”

The man slapped him.

Dante got up.

He told Shawna he didn't remember crossing the space between the tables. One minute he was sitting down. The next he was holding the man against a wall with blood on his own shirt, shouting for someone to bring the old man another fucking bowl.

It bought him punishment and a friendship.

The old man's name was Marcellus Vale.

When Dante came back, Marcellus was sitting on his bunk with a little paper box in his hands. Inside was a broken plastic comb, several buttons, and a gold-colored wrapper folded into a heart.

“For your trouble,” he said.

Dante looked at the heart.

“Nigga, what am I supposed to do with this?”

“Give it to somebody.”

“A woman?”

“If you like women.”

“I like women.”

“Then perhaps one will like a heart.”

Dante took it. The folds were so small and straight they looked pressed by a machine.

“You make jewelry?”

“I did.”

“Used to steal it myself.”

Marcellus looked up.

“Then we may have met professionally.”

Dante laughed. The old man didn't, but he moved over so Dante could sit.

For two months they ate together. Marcellus taught him cards. Dante taught him which men to leave alone and which men only wanted somebody to be frightened of them. Marcellus had already been inside for years. He knew the difference. He let Dante tell him anyway.

At night, the old man held a photograph under the light from the corridor.

Celeste stood on a little stage with a microphone in her hand. Her mouth was open. Her eyes were closed. A blue stone lay at the base of her throat.

“Your wife?” Dante asked one night.

“Yes.”

“She beautiful.”

“I know.”

“She still come see you?”

Marcellus turned the photograph over.

“No.”

Dante didn't ask again until the day a letter arrived and Marcellus sat with it unopened through dinner.

“You want me to read it?” Dante said.

“I know what it says.”

“Then why they send it?”

“Because some people think they can finish a love affair by closing a bank account.”

Dante sat on the other bunk.

Marcellus stared at the envelope.

“She died three months ago.”

Neither man said anything for a while.

Then Dante asked about the diamond.

When Marcellus first saw the stone, it didn't look like forty million dollars. It looked like a dirty piece of sky somebody had knocked loose and tried to bury.

He bought it from a man who carried it in an empty cigarette packet. He paid too much, threatened two people who thought they were entitled to part of it, and came home with an empty account and a fist-sized bruise on his jaw.

Celeste was frying chicken.

She took one look at him and turned the burner down.

“How much?”

“Wait until you see it.”

“How much, Marcellus?”

He put the cigarette packet on the table.

She looked inside. Then she looked at him.

“We are not eating that.”

He took the stone from her and held it toward the kitchen window.

Light passed through the rough blue surface and laid a strange little shape across her white sleeve.

She stopped looking angry for a moment.

“Oh,” she said.

He watched her instead of the stone.

“Yes.”

It took him months to cut it. He worked in a room behind their house, shut the door, and disappeared for days at a time while Celeste sang at a lounge that barely paid her. She brought him food. Half the time it was still there when she came back.

At the end of the first month, she moved his pillow into the workshop.

At the end of the second, she put a photograph of herself beside the lamp.

“So you remember who the fuck lives out here,” she told him.

At the end of the third, he came into the lounge wearing his good suit.

Celeste was halfway through a song. The piano player saw Marcellus coming and lost his place. Celeste stopped, turned, and saw the little box in her husband's hands.

“Don't you propose to me again,” she said into the microphone. “I fell for that shit once.”

People laughed. Marcellus kept walking until he reached the stage.

“I made you something.”

She came down the steps. He opened the box.

The room got quiet.

The stone was blue in a way Dante later told Shawna he couldn't explain. Shawna told me he held her hand against the lamp trying to show her what Marcellus meant. Blue that deepened when you moved it away from the light. Blue that kept looking wet after you understood it was dry.

Celeste put her fingers over her mouth.

“Marcellus.”

He lifted the necklace out.

“Turn around.”

She did. He fastened it behind her neck. The diamond rested against her skin, surrounded by little pale stones that made it look even darker.

“What'd you call it?” she asked.

“Blue Mercy.”

“Mercy for what?”

“The last three months.”

She put her arms around him and kissed him in front of everybody.

Somewhere in that room, a man saw forty million dollars.

Valentino was sitting near the back with Red, who was twenty-eight at the time and hungry for more than he could afford.

Celeste saw her husband coming home from the little room behind the house.

That's the shit Marcellus told Dante. Dante told his new wife. And his wife sat beside me years later with another dead man's necklace in my fist, telling me about all of them.

I wanted to interrupt her, nigga. I wanted to ask whether Dante kissed better than me, whether he had ever promised her more, whether this old nigga's beautiful wife had looked at him the way mine looked at a fucking watch.

I kept my mouth shut, nigga.

Nigga, I wanted to hear what happened more than I wanted to hear myself.

Red came to the workshop two weeks later with T and a bottle of wine that cost more than Marcellus's first car.

He said he wanted to buy the stone.

Marcellus said it wasn't for sale.

Red doubled the number he'd been planning to offer before he even said it.

“It belongs to my wife,” Marcellus told him.

“Then ask your wife.”

“She isn't for sale either.”

T laughed. Red didn't.

They left the wine on the table.

Celeste came in afterward, read the label, and carried it straight to the sink.

Marcellus caught her wrist.

“Do you know what that's worth?”

“Yes.” She pulled free and poured it out. “That's why I don't want to find out what we owe him if we drink it.”

But money was tight. A stone worth a fortune didn't pay the electric bill if nobody intended to sell it. Marcellus agreed to exhibit it at a private showing Valentino arranged. A rich client wanted jewelry made in the same blue setting. Other men wanted to pay him just to look at stones they already owned.

He told Celeste it would give him enough work to stop worrying.

She asked whether he would ever have enough work to stop.

Before the showing, he made a duplicate. A lesser blue stone, convincing under warm light, in an identical necklace. He could leave that in the display while Celeste wore the original. He marked the removable mounting in a place only he thought to check. The true diamond had its own tiny irregularity inside, older than anybody who'd ever owned it. No second stone could share it.

The men who came to the showing took both.

They took the necklaces, the loose jewels in the back room, and the book with his customers' names. T held Marcellus against his own workbench. Valentino lifted the necklace from Celeste's throat so carefully he didn't disturb her hair.

Red stood in the doorway.

“Now,” he said, “perhaps we can agree on a price.”

Marcellus lunged at him. T hit him hard enough to knock the lamp over.

Celeste dropped to the floor beside her husband.

“Take it,” she said to Red. “Go.”

Red looked down at her.

“You should've said that in the beginning.”

He left an envelope on the workbench. There was a fraction of the money inside. Enough that he could say he'd paid. Not enough that any of them could mistake what had happened for a sale.

Marcellus stayed on the floor after they left.

Celeste held a towel against his face.

“Look at me,” she kept saying. “It's gone. Look at me.”

He was looking at her throat.

That was the part that made the old man's voice change when he told Dante.

His wife was right there. She was alive. She was asking him to look at her.

He could only see where the diamond had been.

He went after it. Of course he fucking went after it, nigga. By the time Shawna said that, I was standing beside the window imagining my own hands around Red's throat.

Marcellus took a gun to a place Valentino owned. He found jewelry belonging to women he didn't know, stolen watches, some of his own tools, and men who had been waiting for him.

He shot one of those men. The man lived. Marcellus went to prison.

Red opened the Saint with money raised against a diamond he said he'd bought from a respected jeweler. Marcellus read about it in a magazine somebody left in the visiting room.

Celeste visited him as long as she could.

At first she wore bright dresses and told him stories from the lounge. When he interrupted to ask which men had been asking about the necklace, she told him to eat the candy she'd brought.

Later she came less often because she was sick. He thought she was punishing him. They argued through the glass about a doctor she hadn't mentioned and money he couldn't send.

During her last visit, she wore the earrings he had made before either of them knew a man called Red.

"I want you to do something," she said.

"What?"

"Remember the first thing you ever gave me."

"The earrings."

"No."

“The little bracelet.”

“No, Marcellus.”

He looked at her, frightened now because he couldn't get it right.

“A ride,” she said. “I was standing in the rain. You drove me home. You didn't ask for my number until we got there.”

“I remember.”

“Then remember that man too.”

She put her hand against the glass.

After she died, a letter arrived among her things. Marcellus carried it until the folds began to split. One night he finally unfolded it in front of Dante and read it aloud.

Shawna said Dante had written the words down after he got out because he was scared of forgetting them. He read them to her on their wedding night. She remembered the ones that mattered. When I met Marcellus later that day, he showed me the paper itself, and I read the rest with my own fucking eyes.

My love,

You think I never understood that stone. I did. I understood every hour you spent getting it right. I know the little words you hid beneath the blue mounting. I know you were waiting for me to find them, and I know you were disappointed when I liked the front so much I forgot to look behind it.

I found them the night you fell asleep with your shoes on. I was angry with you for missing supper. I took the necklace off and nearly dropped it, and there you were underneath, saying what you used to say at my door.

I came for you.

I wore those words against me every night afterward. You never asked whether I'd found them. You just watched me wear it and smiled.

I am so tired now, Marcellus. I can't keep driving out there. Don't let anybody tell you I stopped because I stopped loving you. I am stopping because I am sick, and I want the strength I have left for things that don't require me to pass through a locked door.

If you get your beautiful stone back, put it down before you touch somebody you love. I know your hands. They are warmer without all that metal in them.

And if you are still angry when you come home, be angry. You always were. Just open the curtains. Pay the piano man what I owe him. There is chicken in the freezer because I never learned how to cook for one.

I would take the ride again.

Celeste.

Shawna stopped.

Nigga, I was still facing the window. I didn't turn around until I could trust my fucking face.

“What did Dante do?” I asked.

“He told Marcellus he'd get it back.”

“For a man he met in prison?”

“For him. For her. For whatever he thought that would make him.”

“And you?”

Her voice was small when she answered.

“I thought I married the kind of man who'd do that.”

I nodded, nigga. I didn't like the dead nigga any better. I just had a harder time hating him the easy way.

“Dante took the three million first,” she said. “He wanted money to get Marcellus a lawyer and buy us a way out when Red found out

what else he wanted. He thought T would choose him. T was his brother.”

“But he didn't.”

“No.”

She lifted the watch.

“The last night Dante came home, he asked me whether this still looked too big on me. I told him everything he owned was too big on me. He said he'd put something in it that fit.”

I looked at her.

“What something?”

“I thought he meant himself.”

She worked the clasp open with shaking hands.

For the first time since I met her, the dead nigga was about to give us something we could use.

7. Let Him Think You Love Him

Shawna had spent eight months missing Dante. She'd worn the watch since taking it out of Valentino's glove compartment the night she killed him. She had slept with it, showered with it, hit a man with it. Nigga, she had never noticed the back of the clasp was thicker than it needed to be.

I noticed because I was jealous of the motherfucker.

I'd stared at that watch from across tables, across beds, from underneath her hand when she touched my face. My nigga, I knew every scratch on the thing. When she opened it and the small inner piece moved against her thumbnail, I saw the line immediately.

"Wait," I said.

She looked up.

"There's something there."

We didn't know how to open it properly. Shawna called Rosa for the name of a jeweler she trusted. Rosa said she trusted a man who owed her money because she knew where he lived. I said that was close enough, nigga.

The jeweler arrived an hour later, took one look, and asked who had built the clasp.

"Marcellus Vale," Shawna said.

"You know where he is?"

"In prison."

“No,” he said. “He got out nine days ago. Came into my shop asking whether I still had his old bench.”

Shawna grabbed my arm, nigga.

I looked at the jeweler.

“Nigga, call him.”

“I’m not—”

“Then call him whatever you are. Just call the fucking man.”

He did. Marcellus said almost nothing on the phone until Shawna told him her name.

Then, nigga, I heard him ask a question from across the room.

“Dante’s wife?”

She put her hand over her mouth and nodded before she remembered he couldn’t see her.

“Yes.”

The old nigga came before sunset.

He was sixty-two, tall and narrow, with close gray hair and a brown coat that didn’t suit the weather. He carried a paper bag containing a clean shirt. Everything else he’d owned was apparently somewhere he couldn’t get to anymore.

I met my nigga at the front door.

“Aiden.”

“I know.”

“People talking?”

“Dante’s widow said your name six times on the telephone.”

I liked the old nigga right then.

He looked at the cross on my chest. He touched it once, with a fingertip.

“I did those letters.”

“Then come inside, nigga.”

Nigga, Shawna crossed the room too fast and stopped just short of him. For a second neither of them knew what to do. Then he put the paper bag down and opened his arms.

She cried against his coat.

I watched the old nigga's hand settle carefully between her shoulders. His eyes closed. He hadn't seen Dante die. Neither had she. They had each kept a different part of him alive, and now they were standing in my expensive fucking living room discovering the other part had been real.

My nigga Tank came in from outside carrying a bag of food. He saw them, lowered the bag, and went quiet.

“Who this?” he asked me.

“Marcellus.”

Tank looked toward the door.

The old nigga looked at Tank's face for a long second.

“Your friend?” he asked me.

“Yeah, nigga.”

“I see.”

He didn't say anything else. Tank put the food down and went back outside.

Marcellus opened the watch while we waited at the table. My nigga worked with the patience of a man who had spent years having nowhere to hurry.

Dante had asked him about a place to keep a letter when they were still inside. After Dante got out, a watch had reached Marcellus through a legal repair commission arranged by an old client. He had made the clasp for him and sent it back. I let the old man finish telling me that because I wanted to hear Dante had planned to live long enough to read whatever he hid.

Nigga, a thin folded piece of paper lay inside.

Marcellus set it on the table. He put his hands flat beside it and didn't touch it again.

Shawna opened it.

The paper had been torn from a longer note. Red ink. The same slanted, crowded handwriting I'd been holding in the car that morning.

T — He has the withdrawal and Vale's story. If he gets the stone, he can name every one of us. Finish Dante tonight. No more brother shit. Valentino takes the watch. Keep her alive. I'll deal with her. R.

Underneath, in darker ink, Dante had written four words.

Shawna. If I'm wrong.

She read it twice. The third time she didn't finish.

“No,” she said.

I reached for her hand. She pulled away and stood so quickly the chair fell over.

“No. He knew?”

Marcellus watched the note.

“He suspected.”

“He fucking knew.”

I picked up the paper, and everything in me went still.

Nigga, there wasn't a word on it about protecting her. There wasn't a word about Valentino acting alone. Red had ordered a man's death and chosen where the widow would go before the body was cold.

I heard the nigga saying he'd bought her dress.

I heard the nigga saying the piano was still there.

“Nigga,” I said very quietly.

Marcellus looked at me.

I had no idea which of those dead motherfuckers Dante had taken that note from. I didn't know why he hadn't run the minute he read it. He had still written *if*, like he could find some version of those words that didn't mean what they meant.

I knew that part. T had put his hand on my neck and called me son. I had been ready to believe the nigga right up until he told me to fetch Shawna.

She was standing by the window with both hands on her head.

“He went to talk to his brother,” she said. “He told me there was a mistake he had to straighten out. I was mad because he wouldn’t stay for dinner.”

Marcellus closed his eyes.

“I told him I’d throw his plate away.”

I got up.

“Shawna.”

“Don’t say it.”

“I wasn’t—”

“Don’t fucking say there was nothing I could do. I could’ve locked the door. I could’ve gone with him. I could’ve—”

“You could’ve died too.”

She slapped me.

Hard. Right across the mouth that still wasn’t properly healed.

Nigga, I stood there with blood coming back onto my tongue.

Her hand stayed in the air.

“Aiden.”

I took a breath through my nose, my nigga. The whole room was waiting for me to become the worst man in it.

Nigga, I reached for her wrist, lowered her hand, and let go.

“I’m going outside, nigga.”

I went outside.



Tank was by the lake throwing pieces of bread to the birds. The nigga looked up when he saw my mouth.

“What happened?”

“Don't.”

My nigga put the bread down.

I stood beside him until I could breathe without wanting to break something that had cost me money.

“She hit you?”

“Nigga, I said don't.”

“All right.”

Nigga, a bird walked up between us and took the whole remaining roll.

Tank watched it go.

“That was mine.”

“Go tell him, nigga.”

He didn't move.

Nigga, I almost laughed. It hurt too much, so I sat on the low wall instead.

“Red ordered it,” I told him. “Dante. We got his own fucking handwriting.”

Tank stared at the water.

“You know?”

“No.”

“You heard anything?”

“I heard Dante took money.”

“And that's all?”

“That was all anybody was saying around me.”

He looked at me finally.

“I didn't know him like that. T had me moving things. Driving people. I wasn't in every room.”

I wanted to believe the nigga. I wanted somebody I loved to tell me a complete fucking thing before another man handed me the part they'd left out.

“I'm taking Red's diamond,” I said.

Tank's jaw shifted.

“And then?”

“And then I'm going to look at how poor the motherfucker got.”

“Forty million ain't all he has.”

“Then I'll stay busy, nigga.”

The back door opened, nigga. Shawna came out carrying a wet cloth. She had taken Dante's watch off. It was in her other hand.

Tank picked up the empty bread bag and walked away.

She stood in front of me.

“I shouldn't have done that.”

“No shit.”

“Can I see?”

I let her touch my chin, nigga. She cleaned the blood off my mouth, and I looked past her because I was still too angry to look at her without saying something cruel.

“I love him,” she said.

“I fucking know, Shawna.”

“I love you too.”

“You tell him that before he left?” I asked.

She shook her head.

“I was mad about dinner.”

I looked at her then, my nigga.

She put the cloth down and touched my face with her empty hand.

“I love you,” she said again.

Nigga, I took her hand and pressed it against my chest so she could feel what the shit was doing to me.

“Don't hit me again.”

“I won't.”

“And don't take that watch off because you think it'll shut me up, nigga. Put it back on. I want the whole thing when you tell me something.”

She looked down at it.

Then she put it back on.

We ate the food my nigga Tank had bought. Marcellus kept Celeste's old letter beside his plate in a clear sleeve. He let me read

it while he ate. When I gave it back, he put it inside his coat with the same careful movement Shawna used with Dante's photograph.

“You want your stone?” I asked him.

“Yes.”

“You want Red dead?”

He looked at Shawna.

“Yes.”

“Nigga, I think we can work together.”

He didn't smile.

Shawna laid the invitations on the table.

“He's putting it on display in three nights.”

Marcellus picked one up. The front showed a blue necklace I recognized from Shawna's description.

“He's putting something on display,” he said.

“There's two,” I said.

“Yes.”

“You tell them apart?”

“Of course.”

“Then you're going.”

“He knows my face.”

“He knows the face he put in prison eight years ago, nigga. We'll give you another suit and somebody else's name.”

Rosa, who had come back while we were eating, looked at him.

“I know a woman who can make you look like a man with money.”

Marcellus looked around my dining room.

“Apparently it's easy to confuse people.”

Tank covered his mouth with his napkin. I let the old nigga have that one. He'd been through a lot.

“There are different settings,” Marcellus said. “The blue outer mounting can be removed. A buyer might wear the stone another way. The original has a flaw inside it. Very small. I remember exactly where it is. The copy doesn't.”

“But the necklace in the picture?” Shawna asked.

“Could hold either.”

I sat back.

“Then we get you close enough to look.”

Red wanted her back. That was the part we had that forty million dollars couldn't buy him. He wanted Shawna walking into his room while other men watched. Nigga, he wanted every motherfucker who'd heard she left him to see her choose him instead.

Shawna knew it too.

“I can get him to invite us closer,” she said.

“No.”

“Aiden.”

“No, nigga.”

“You haven't heard what I'm saying.”

“I heard it in the way you sat up.”

She reached across the table and took my hand.

“I tell him I made a mistake. That you scare me. That I'm bringing you to the gala because I want him to handle it quietly.”

Tank looked at her.

“And he believes that?”

“He wants to.”

My fingers tightened around hers.

“What else?”

“I tell him I know where your money is.”

“I don't have his fucking money.”

“He doesn't know that.”

Tank put his glass down a little too carefully. I was watching Shawna. I missed it until later.

“Tell him I'm tired of running,” she said. “Tell him I'll come back if he clears the debt and leaves you alive.”

“Nigga, why he going to leave me alive?”

“Because I'm going to say you can give him the west side.”

I let go of her hand.

The room went quiet again.

She leaned toward me, nigga.

“I'm saying what he'll listen to. You know that.”

I did know, nigga. It still felt like watching her put on the dress he'd bought.

Marcellus folded the invitation and set it down.

"If he believes she can give you to him, he'll want you close enough to take."

"Then he can fucking try, nigga."

Rosa looked at Shawna. "You get near the jewel, the old man looks at it, we leave with what's his. You do not decide to kill somebody in the middle because you get mad."

Shawna said nothing.

Rosa pointed at me.

"You either."

"Nigga, why everybody looking at me?"

"Because you have the face," she said.

Tank nodded as if that settled it.

Shawna made the call from our bedroom with me sitting beside her.

Red answered on the second ring.

"There she is."

She closed her eyes. I put my hand on her knee.

"Can you talk?"

"For you?"

Nigga, I wanted to take the phone and put it through the fucking wall. I left my hand where it was.

“I think I made a mistake,” she said.

Red didn't answer immediately.

Outside, the lake had gone black. Our reflection floated in the window: her with the phone, me beside her like a man waiting for a verdict.

“He hurt you?” Red asked.

Nigga, she looked at the cut on my mouth.

“I don't know what he's going to do next.”

“Come home.”

“I can't just leave.”

“Yes, you can.”

“You want the money. You want his streets. I can bring him to you, Red. But you have to promise me something.”

“Anything.”

The ease of it made me sick. The nigga had put a man's death in a note shorter than the promises he was making to his widow.

“You let him live,” she said.

Red sighed.

“You're too good to these boys.”

Nigga, my hand left her knee.

My nigga, she caught it before I could stand.

“I know where he's keeping the money,” she said. “I can get him to bring what you need. At the gala, I'll stay close to you. Everybody can see I'm back. After that, you talk to him.”

“And you stay?”

She looked at me.

“Yes.”

Red let out a breath into the phone. Nigga, I heard the pleasure in it. I heard how badly the nigga had wanted to win.

“Wear the blue dress,” he said. “The one I liked.”

“I will.”

“And Shawna?”

“What?”

“I knew you'd remember who loved you.”

She hung up without answering.

I knew it was a lie, nigga. I had helped make it. Every fucking word still hurt.

She took my face in both hands.

“Look at me, Aiden.”

I did.

“I'm here.”

Nigga, I pulled her into me, too hard, and my side burned. I held on anyway.

Downstairs, the old man was measuring the empty space where his wife's diamond ought to have been. Tank was on the phone with

somebody he wasn't ready to name. Rosa was choosing a dress that would make a killer forget the last thing he'd been careful about.

And me, nigga? I was holding my woman and imagining forty million dollars in one hand, Red's whole fucking life in the other.

Three nights.

Nigga, I could wait three nights.

I told myself that until morning.

8. Forty Million and One Woman

I bought a white suit for the robbery because I wanted Red to see who ruined his fucking life.

The tailor tried to sell me black. Then he tried to sell me dark blue. He had Shawna on a little velvet chair behind me, drinking champagne and telling him I looked handsome in everything, which meant she hadn't looked up from her phone once.

“White, my nigga,” I told him. “The whole thing.”

“Your injury—”

“Nigga, is the suit going to heal me?”

The nigga stopped talking about the injury.

Tank stood beside the door in a black suit we had bought forty minutes earlier. He had already torn it reaching for a peppermint. The tailor was pretending not to notice. I wasn't, my nigga.

“Get the nigga another one too.”

“A larger size?”

“Get that nigga whatever size a cathedral is.”

Tank put the peppermint back.

“Eat your candy, nigga. We rich.”

Shawna laughed then. She lifted her eyes, and for a second I had her. No dead husband. No diamond. No Red waiting for his chance. Just my woman laughing because I was standing in a

thousand pins threatening to buy a church-sized suit for the biggest motherfucker in Nevada.

My nigga, I would've bought the actual church to keep her laughing.

The three days before the gala had done something terrible to me. I could take a bullet. I could bury a man who called himself my father. But sitting beside Shawna while she told Red over the phone that she missed him had me walking around my own house like I was looking for somebody to rob.

I knew the plan. Nigga, I had agreed to the plan. I had nodded while she explained it and said some shit about trusting her. Then she had put Red on speaker and called him baby, and all that intelligent shit left my body.

“You don't have to say it to that nigga like that,” I told her afterward.

“Like what?”

“With your mouth.”

She stared at me.

“Aiden.”

“Nigga got a name. Use the name.”

She hung up on the argument by kissing me. I let her. The second night I made the same complaint, and she kissed me again. By the third, she knew exactly what I was doing and told me to come over there without starting a fight first.

Now the tailor knelt beside my shoes while she answered another message.

“That nigga again?”

“Rosa.”

“Let me see.”

She turned the screen. Rosa had sent a picture of six gowns thrown across a bed and the words *Your nigga paying for all this?*

“Tell her your nigga said yes.”

“You don't know how much it is.”

“Tell her yes in capital fucking letters.”

Shawna put her phone away. Then she stood and walked around the tailor to straighten my collar herself.

“You know you're allowed to be scared tonight.”

“I'm not.”

“Okay.”

“You are?”

“Yes.”

I caught her wrist before she could step away. Dante's watch slid down against my fingers. I let it.

“Then your nigga scared too.”

She kissed the uncut corner of my mouth.

“Good. Maybe you'll listen.”

I listened to every fucking thing she said. I just sometimes decided the whole world was wrong after I heard it.

At the house, Rosa had turned our bedroom into a kingdom of women getting dressed. There were shoes on the chairs, perfume in the air, and a bottle of champagne standing in the sink beside my toothbrush. Somebody had moved my gun to make room for a heated hairbrush. Nigga, I owned the house, and they asked me why I was in there.

“Nigga, because I sleep here.”

“Not while we're busy,” Rosa said.

She was wearing red, diamonds at her throat, and an expression that told me she had already decided who was going to disappoint her that night.

“I need Shawna.”

“Your nigga needs patience,” Rosa told Shawna.

“Nigga, I bought patience. They said it'll be here tomorrow.”

Rosa picked up a shoe. A nigga left.

Downstairs, Marcellus sat by the windows in a gray suit. Somebody had polished his shoes until they looked wet. The disguise was supposed to make him a wealthy old jeweler, which mostly involved getting him a better jacket and telling him not to look like he wanted Red dragged behind a car.

My nigga still looked like that.

On the table in front of him lay Celeste's letter. The folds were so worn they looked ready to separate. He wasn't reading it. He had laid one hand across the paper like somebody might reach down from heaven and take it back.

“You ready, my nigga?” I asked.

“I have been ready for years.”

“Nigga, that's not what I asked.”

He looked up, and for the first time since I met him, the old man almost smiled.

“Yes, Aiden.”

I sat across from him. My side objected. That bullet had settled into my life like it intended to pay rent. Every time I forgot it, the pain came back to tell me who had put it there.

Marcellus glanced at the way I lowered myself.

“Does she know how much that hurts?”

“She knows everything.”

“Does she, my nigga?”

I looked toward the stairs, my nigga.

“Nigga, she knows enough.”

He folded Celeste's letter and put it in his inside pocket.

“The stone cannot love you back,” he said.

“I got somebody for that.”

“Then remember which one you came for.”

Before I could answer, Tank walked in holding two phones. He turned one facedown as soon as he saw us.

“Cars ready, nigga.”

“What nigga calling you?”

“Nobody.”

“Nigga, then why you got two phones?”

“In case somebody does.”

I would've laughed on any other night. That night I watched him put both in his pocket, and something in my stomach moved. I thought about asking again. Then I heard Shawna on the stairs.

My nigga, everything in me turned around.

She wore blue. Dark blue, cut close to her body, with a train dragging behind her like even the floor wanted to hold on. Diamonds touched her ears. Dante's watch was on her wrist. Her hair was up, and that little scar above her eyebrow stood out plainly. I loved the scar. I loved knowing the exact place on her face where the world had tried some shit and failed.

“Rosa's dress,” she said when she saw me looking. “She never wore it.”

“Nigga, I said I'd buy you anything.”

“I wanted this one.”

Rosa lifted the train off the last stair.

“And I want it back. Both of you hear me?”

“Yes,” Shawna said.

I should've heard how softly she said it.

Rosa came down behind her carrying a small envelope.

“I've got the watch paper,” she said. “The original. Nobody gets it off me.”

The order hidden in Dante's watch was inside. Red's words. Red's decision. All the grief he had handed Shawna while pretending he was helping her carry it.

Shawna had made a copy for tonight. Rosa would keep the original safe, along with the truth if none of us came back.

I didn't like thinking about that second part, so I stood up.

"Turn around for your nigga," I told Shawna.

She did.

"Again."

"Aiden."

"Nigga, I'm trying to remember whether there's anybody left alive I need to thank."

She came over and put her hands against my chest.

She slipped her little silver pistol into her purse before she put both hands against my chest again.

"If you tear this dress, I'm killing you before Red gets the chance."

"Your nigga will buy the factory."

"I'll kill you in the factory."

I kissed her. I kissed her until Tank cleared his throat, then I kissed her again because that nigga did not determine the length of my happiness.

We went to the Saint in four cars.

I wanted six. Tank said we only had enough people for four. I told him to put one nigga in each of the other two, and he asked who was driving. Apparently the man had chosen tonight to become a fucking mathematician.

Four cars pulled under the Saint's canopy. Four cars full of my niggas. It still looked like a palace somebody had built with all the money they should've used to raise their children. Gold everywhere. Flowers as tall as men. A fountain full of coins that were worth less than one button on the security guard's jacket.

Red had made the gala white tie. Nigga thought if he dressed his sins in enough silk, God might mistake them for somebody else's.

I came out in my white suit with the cross against my chest and Shawna beside me. Cameras started flashing.

My nigga, that surprised me. I had expected guns.

"Keep walking," she whispered.

I kept walking like I had paid for the fucking sidewalk.

A photographer asked us to stop against a wall of white roses. Shawna put her hand on my shoulder. I put mine at her waist. A man with a microphone asked whether I was taking over Big T's interests.

"Every nigga that owes them anything owes me," I said.

"And your relationship with Mr. Redmond?"

Redmond. Nigga had a government name tonight.

"Ask me at the end."

Rosa stepped between the reporter and us before I could make it worse. Tank followed so closely I felt his jacket brush mine. For a second his hand touched my arm.

“Anything happen tonight, nigga,” he said, “you stay with me.”

“Nigga, that was already the idea.”

The nigga didn't answer.

Inside, a staircase curved around a statue of a naked woman holding a bowl of fire. Red had put real flames in the bowl. I respected that nigga for that one thing. If you were going to waste money, nigga, make the building itself nervous.

Women in jewels walked past women who had sold them drugs in the bathroom. Men greeted men they had paid to have killed and had not yet heard back about. A preacher I recognized from television stood beside a man whose entire fortune came from stolen cars. The preacher had the bigger watch.

There was a private lounge full of cocaine and champagne. Somebody called my name from inside. I looked over and saw a man I had spent a filthy weekend with before I ever met Shawna, sitting between two women I had met the same weekend.

He lifted his glass.

“Aiden, nigga! You disappear when you fall in love?”

“Nigga, I got promoted.”

The women laughed. Shawna looked at all three, then at me.

“All of them?”

“Your nigga had a long weekend.”

“You nasty motherfucker.”

“You love me.”

She squeezed my hand hard enough to hurt.

“Don't get confident.”

I got confident. I got so fucking confident that when Red came down the far staircase in a dark green jacket, I smiled at him like he had arrived at my party.

He wasn't looking at me.

He was looking at Shawna.

“There she is,” Red said. Nigga sounded like she had come out of his own prayers.

He held out both hands. She gave him one. He kissed it above Dante's watch.

Nigga, I saw the whole murder happen in my mind. His head through the flower arrangement. His green jacket on fire. Me standing over him while the preacher told God to mind His business.

Instead I smiled.

“Good party, nigga.”

Red finally looked at me.

“You clean up well, nigga.”

“You still talking.”

Shawna's fingers tightened against my arm.

Red laughed softly, as if I was a child who had threatened to buy his own house.

“We should get a photograph. All three of us, nigga.”

Before anybody could object, he called the photographer over. He put Shawna in the middle. Then he rested a hand against her upper arm. On that hand he wore a broad dark ring with a blue stone set almost flush into it.

Marcellus, a few feet behind us, went perfectly still.

The flash went off.

The nigga asked for another.

I stared straight into the lens. If that photograph ever hung in a museum, nigga, people would know which motherfucker had come there to kill somebody.

An attendant brought glossy little copies while Red greeted Rosa. Rosa took two. She tucked them into her purse with a smile I knew cost her real effort.

“Now,” Red said, holding out his arm to Shawna, “I promised this woman a dance.”

Shawna looked at me.

I remembered every word of the plan. I remembered agreeing. I remembered her saying she needed him close and foolish and thinking he had already won.

I also remembered that I had hands.

“One dance, nigga,” I said.

Red smiled.

“Let's see what she wants, nigga.”

Then he took my woman onto the floor, and I followed them with my eyes like a nigga watching his own heart get carried through traffic.

9. Blue Mercy

The band started playing a song Shawna knew.

I knew she knew it because her face changed before the singer got to the first word. Red saw the change too. He said something against her ear, and she looked down at their hands.

Nigga, I wanted to rip the song out of the speakers.

They turned beneath a chandelier that probably cost enough to feed everybody I had grown up with until the end of time. Red held her close. Not too close for a ballroom. Too close for me.

Tank brought me a drink.

“Don't throw it, nigga.”

“Then why you bring it, nigga?”

“Thought you might drink it, nigga.”

I swallowed half. My side burned. Across the room Marcellus spoke to an older woman wearing a necklace so heavy she looked like she was being slowly arrested by it. He looked ordinary. Harmless. I knew he had a dead wife folded over his heart and a fury older than mine.

That made two of us watching the same dance for different ghosts.

Red turned Shawna. Her blue dress swung around his legs. She smiled at something he said.

“Nigga,” I told Tank.

“Nigga, I see.”

“Nigga.”

“I know.”

“No, nigga, you don't.”

My nigga drank his whole glass.

Shawna told me later what Red said during that dance. She told me every word because I asked her every word, and because some nights loving a woman means hearing the part that makes you want to break your own furniture.

He began with the song.

“You used to sing this upstairs.”

“I sang a lot of things.”

“Before Dante.”

“I had a life before all of you.”

Red drew her a little closer. To everybody else, they looked beautiful. Two people moving together at a party full of people who believed beauty was the best possible excuse.

“You could have that life now.”

“Could I?”

“Whatever you want.”

She looked at the ring on his hand. Blue against the green sleeve. He noticed her looking and turned his hand away to bring her through another step.

“I want him left alone,” she said.

“Already thinking about that nigga?”

“His name is Aiden.”

“I know what the nigga's name is.”

Red smiled for somebody passing them. Shawna had to smile too.

“You said you were tired of running,” he said when they were alone inside the music again.

“I am.”

“You said you wanted to come home.”

“I said I wanted somewhere I could sleep.”

“My bed was never the problem.”

She almost pulled away then. I had seen it from across the room: the small hard line her shoulder made beneath his hand.

He held on.

“Don't do that tonight, Shawna.”

“Then don't talk to me like that.”

For a moment he stopped guiding her. They stood with couples turning on either side.

“Do you know what it felt like?” he asked. “Standing there while he put that ring on you? Paying for a room where you were going to spend the night with him?”

“Dante was your friend.”

“Nigga knew.”

“Knew what?”

“That his nigga saw you first.”

Shawna looked him in the face.

“You all keep saying that like I was a fucking parking space.”

His fingers tightened. Then loosened. He gave another careful smile to the room.

“I could've given you everything.”

“Then give me the diamond.”

The song carried on without them.

“That's what tonight is for,” she said. “You said you wanted me to know how serious you were. Show me.”

“And Aiden?”

“You let him walk out.”

Red looked across the floor at me.

“Will he?”

Shawna put her hand against his cheek.

“He will if I tell him to.”

That was the part of the dance I could see. Her touching his face. His eyes going soft. My woman telling another man something that made him look at me like I was already gone.

I finished my drink.

Nigga, I should've broken the glass in my own hand. It would've been less stupid than what I did next.

Nigga, I went onto the floor.

Tank said my name. Rosa stepped toward me. I kept moving.

I told myself I would only take Shawna aside for a second. Ask if she was all right. Let Red know that whatever he imagined was happening, there was a living nigga standing right there with a say in it.

“Dance over, nigga,” I said.

Red didn't stop.

“The band's still playing, nigga.”

I put a hand on his shoulder.

Now he stopped.

Shawna looked at my hand. Then my face. She was trying to tell me something without making a sound, and I was trying so hard to prove I loved her that I stopped listening.

“Take your hand off me, nigga,” Red said quietly.

“Take yours off her, nigga.”

Three men in dark jackets moved from the edge of the room. Tank moved too. The singer saw what was happening and missed a word. The band kept playing under it.

Shawna stepped between us.

“Aiden. Go sit down.”

I stared at her.

“What?”

“You're embarrassing me.”

Nigga, I knew it was supposed to be a lie. I knew we had agreed she might have to hurt my feelings in front of him. Nobody had explained that my feelings were going to show up with fucking guns.

“You mean that about your nigga?”

She slapped me.

The sound cracked across the music. The whole room seemed to turn on the same neck.

I looked back at her. Her hand was shaking.

“I told you,” she said, her eyes bright with fury that wasn't all pretend, “to listen to me.”

Red watched us like somebody had just handed him a country.

I stepped back.

For one second, Shawna's face begged me to understand. Then she covered it and turned toward Red.

“Let's finish our dance.”

They moved away together.

I stood there with the whole fucking gala looking at me, and I had never needed a gun less or wanted one more.

Tank caught my sleeve.

“Come on, nigga.”

“Don't, nigga.”

“Come on.”

He brought me to the side of the room. I let him because I couldn't see where to put my feet.

Rosa came up beside us.

“She just kept you alive, nigga,” she said.

“I know, nigga.”

“Then act like you know.”

I looked at the floor. My cheek burned where she had hit me. My side burned where T had shot me. Apparently every nigga I loved came with a different place to hurt.

Across the ballroom, Red kissed Shawna's hand again.

This time I stayed where I was.

At nine, Red had the music stopped.

He walked onto a low stage with Shawna beside him. Behind them, attendants opened a curtain. A glass case stood under a white light.

Inside lay Blue Mercy.

I had spent three days hearing about that diamond. Forty million dollars. A marriage. A prison. Dante bleeding in the desert because he had come too close to the truth. Nigga, I expected the thing to stand up and say my name.

Nigga, it was smaller than I expected.

My nigga, that made it worse.

A little blue light in a velvet cradle, and all those lives wrapped around it. I looked at Marcellus. The old man's face went slack. Whatever he had prepared himself to feel, it hadn't been enough. Red took the microphone.

"Some things wait a long time to come home."

He looked at Shawna when he said it. People clapped. Nigga had spent his life hurting people and learned to pause in the places where strangers would congratulate him.

"Tonight isn't an auction," he said. "Nobody in this room can afford what this means to me."

A man in the front laughed too loudly. Red didn't look at him.

"Tonight is a promise."

He held Shawna's hand up for the room. Dante's watch slid toward her elbow.

I heard Tank say something under his breath. I didn't ask what.

Marcellus moved forward with the jeweler's case we had brought for him. Red's men let him approach the stage. A name was given. A profession. The old man inclined his head as if he had spent his entire life attending evenings like this without wanting to burn one down.

Red watched him closely.

"You approve?"

Marcellus looked at the glass.

"I would like to see it closer."

"Later."

“A piece of this age deserves—”

“Later,” Red repeated.

His ring flashed blue when he lowered the microphone.

Marcellus looked at his hand again.

Then Shawna turned. She found me in the crowd and held my eyes. The plan was still moving. She needed me to move with it.

I nodded once.

Nigga, it felt like swallowing a knife.

An attendant came for me after the presentation.

“Mr. Redmond would like you upstairs.”

“Nigga can come get me.”

Tank touched my arm.

The attendant waited.

I looked toward Shawna. She was speaking to Rosa beside the stage. Rosa had a hand at her back. Both of them looked over when the attendant repeated the invitation.

Shawna nodded.

Fine. Nigga wanted a private conversation, I would give him a private conversation. I was tired of standing under expensive lights while he performed his ownership of everything I wanted alive.

Tank came with me. So did Marcellus. The attendant objected to the old man, and I told him if his boss was giving away forty

million dollars, he could let a jeweler look at it before everybody left.

Red's office was above the ballroom. You could hear the party through the floor. The doors opened onto dark wood, city windows, and a desk big enough to lay a king out on.

Red stood behind it. Shawna was already there, having come through another door. She held a small blue box.

"I thought you might prefer privacy," Red said.

"For what, nigga?"

"The end."

Shawna took a step toward me.

Red put his hand on her shoulder.

"Tell him."

Her face was pale. I didn't know how much of it was acting anymore.

"Aiden, take the box."

"Come here to your nigga."

"Take it."

She held it out. I took it because her hand was shaking, and because for a moment all I could think about was making that stop.

Inside lay the blue stone from the ballroom.

Red watched my face.

"Forty million," he said. "Enough to start over anywhere."

I looked at him.

“Nigga, you think I'm selling her?”

“I think she just sold you, nigga.”

Marcellus stepped forward. Red lifted one finger. Two men appeared beside the door.

The old man stopped.

Shawna's eyes moved from Red to the men, then back to me.

Something had changed. We had come to steal the diamond and take the truth. Red was handing me the diamond. He had stopped asking questions. He looked like a man standing in a grave he had dug for somebody else.

He opened a drawer.

“And since your friends are so interested in history.”

He put a flat leather folder on the desk.

DANTE was written across a white label.

Shawna made a sound I had never heard from her before.

I reached for the folder.

Red let me take it.

That was when I knew we were in serious fucking trouble.

10. The Money at the Bottom

The first page had a date. The second had numbers. On the third, beside Valentino's name, somebody had written *settled* in red ink.

Under it was a copy of the order we had found in the watch.

Red had kept his own.

I looked up at him.

“Nigga, you sick motherfucker.”

“Careful, nigga.”

Shawna snatched the pages from my hand. She found the order. Read it. Turned the page like there might be something on the other side that could make it less real.

She already knew what it said. I had watched her read the original. Knowing didn't make her ready to see it sitting in a drawer under the man's desk, waiting beside his good pens.

“You kept this?” she asked.

Red didn't answer her directly.

“T believed in records. Nigga kept everything.”

“You're sitting behind the desk.”

“Shawna.”

“You're sitting behind the fucking desk.”

She threw the order at him. It struck his chest and fell across the edge of the blotter.

He looked down at it. Then at me.

“I was going to make this generous.”

“Nigga, shut your mouth.”

Tank moved closer to me. The men at the door moved with him.

Red noticed. His expression changed into something almost happy.

“Maybe you should ask your man what generosity looks like.”

Tank went still.

I turned toward him.

“What the fuck is this nigga talking about?”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga. What?”

Red picked up a remote from the desk. A screen on the wall lit up.

An empty swimming pool filled it.

For a second I was back at the motel. T's gun against my side.

Shawna on the balcony. Cash blowing across blue tiles while I tried to keep another man from deciding whether I got to breathe.

Then I saw Tank climbing down into the pool.

On the recording, our Mercedes was already gone.

Tank had a bag.

He began putting the money inside.

I watched until I couldn't.

“Turn it off, nigga.”

Red left it playing.

Onscreen, Tank went back for another bag. The nigga stepped around the same place where T had fallen, leaned over, and picked up a loose bundle beside his shoe.

“Nigga. Turn it the fuck off.”

Red pressed the remote.

The office became quiet enough that I could hear Shawna breathing.

“Three million, nigga,” Red said. “All of it. Your friend is thorough.”

Tank looked at me. He didn't look away when I turned on him.

“Nigga, you took her money?”

“I took the money out the pool, nigga.”

“Don't play with me, nigga.”

“I'm not.”

“You watched her hold me together. You saw her drive off with me bleeding. And you went back for the fucking money?”

His jaw moved.

“Yes.”

I hit him.

I couldn't even remember deciding to. My fist caught the side of his face. Pain went through my ribs so hard my knees almost followed it. Tank stayed where he was.

I hit him again.

He took that one too.

“Hit me back, nigga.”

“No.”

“Hit me the fuck back.”

Shawna caught my arm. Tank's mouth was bleeding. He looked at her, then at me.

“I'm not hitting you.”

Red leaned against his desk.

“This is touching.”

I turned so fast Shawna tightened her grip.

“You say one more word—”

“And what? You'll die rich?”

He glanced at the blue box in my hand.

I had forgotten I was holding it. Forty million dollars, and I wanted to throw it through his fucking face.

Marcellus stepped closer to the desk. His eyes moved over the stone under the lamp. The look on his face stopped me.

“Aiden,” he said.

Red looked at him.

The old man didn't stop looking at the box.

“Close it.”

“What?”

“Close the box.”

I did.

He raised his eyes to mine.

Whatever he had seen, he didn't want Red hearing it yet.

Tank wiped his mouth with the back of his hand.

“It's at your house. Back of my closet. I moved it when we moved in.”

Shawna stared at him.

“All of it?”

“Every fucking dollar.”

“Why didn't you tell us?”

He looked down at the floor. Then he looked back up because I had stepped toward him again.

“Because I thought you was going to leave.”

That stopped me for half a breath.

“Nigga, what?”

“You got her. T was dead. You had the car. You was talking about water and houses and taking her anywhere. I thought you was gone.”

“Nigga, I was fucking dying.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

His eyes filled, which made me angrier. Tank was not supposed to do that. Tank was supposed to be something solid I could hit until the rest of the world made sense.

“I thought if you left, I'd have something,” he said. “That's it. That's the whole thing.”

Red shook his head.

“Tell the nigga the rest.”

Tank looked at Red.

“You called me.”

“And you answered, nigga.”

“You sent me that video.”

“And you answered again.”

Shawna let go of my arm.

“You told him where we were?”

“No.”

“Tank.”

“No, Shawna. I didn't tell him about the house by the lake. Didn't tell him what you was doing. He knew you were coming here because you fucking told him.”

Red's smile thinned.

“I offered him his place back.”

I looked at Tank.

“What place, nigga?”

“Yours,” Red said.

The room seemed to move farther away from me. All those nights with Tank outside my door. The spare phone. The way he watched when I called men who used to answer to T and heard them answer to me instead.

“You want it?” I asked him.

Tank said nothing.

“Nigga, I'm standing right here. You want it?”

He looked at my white suit. At the red mark coming through near my side. I hadn't noticed it before.

Then he shook his head.

“I wanted you to ask me to stay.”

I didn't have an answer ready for that. Nigga, I had an answer ready for a hundred different betrayals. That one caught me with my hands empty.

Red opened another drawer. Took out a car key and tossed it onto the desk.

“You can still make the intelligent decision,” he told Tank. “Bring me my money. Walk out of here with a future.”

Tank looked at the key.

He picked it up.

My whole body went cold.

Then the nigga threw it through Red's window.

The glass cracked under the impact without breaking apart. The key bounced down onto the carpet.

Tank looked at the window. Then at Red.

“Fuck your car too.”

Everything happened close.

One of Red's men caught Tank by the shoulder. Tank turned and drove him into the wall hard enough to knock a framed picture sideways. The other man reached inside his jacket.

Shawna grabbed the desk lamp and smashed it across his arm.

The room flashed white as the bulb burst. Red caught her from behind. I went toward them, and the man beside the door hit me in the side with something heavy.

Nigga, the whole world left my lungs.

I fell against the desk. Papers slid beneath my hands. Red dragged Shawna toward the inner door while she fought him, her shoes scraping the floor.

“Let her go.”

It came out barely louder than breathing.

I tried again.

“Let her fucking go.”

Tank tore the man away from me. Marcellus caught my sleeve and pulled me upright. I had the blue box in one hand and Dante's folder under the other. I don't know why I held on. Maybe because

letting go of one more thing felt like the end of the whole fucking world.

A gun went off.

The sound filled the room. A piece of wood jumped from the desk beside my hand. Somebody downstairs screamed, then more people screamed, then the party stopped pretending to be beautiful.

Red had Shawna in front of him by the inner doorway.

The gun was against her.

I stopped.

Tank stopped.

For one second, everybody did exactly what Red wanted.

“There,” he said. “You can learn.”

Shawna's hair had come down. One earring was gone. She stared at me over his arm, and I could see her trying not to cry because she thought that would make me do something stupid.

Nigga, I was already past stupid. I was standing in the place where I would've paid for my next breath with every life in the building if it let me reach her.

“Take me,” I said.

Red looked almost offended.

“Nigga, I don't want you.”

“Let her walk, nigga. I'll stay.”

“I heard you.”

Shawna shook her head. Just once. Hard.

“Aiden.”

I couldn't look away from the gun.

“Aiden, take it and go.”

“I'm not leaving you.”

“Go.”

The inner door opened wider. Another man stood behind Red. Shawna saw him before I did. Something in her eyes changed, and she used the last second she had to look straight at Tank.

“Get him out.”

Then Red pulled her through the door.

I went after them.

Tank caught me around the chest. I fought that nigga harder than I had fought anybody the night they jumped me in. I hit him in the face. In the shoulder. I told him I would kill him. I meant it. He kept pulling me away while a man behind us shouted and another shot struck the wall.

Marcellus was at the outer door. Rosa appeared beyond him with her red dress gathered in one fist. Her face changed when she saw Shawna wasn't with us.

“Where is she?”

“He has her,” Marcellus said.

Rosa tried to go past him.

The old man caught her hand.

“Not this way.”

Tank dragged me into the hall.

I could still hear Shawna on the other side of the office.

Then I couldn't.

The Saint emptied around us in silk and terror.

Men who had told each other they feared nothing crawled behind tables. A woman ran holding her shoes and a bottle of champagne. Somebody kept asking whether the diamond was insured. Nigga, I would've burned forty million dollars in his mouth if I could've found the strength to stand up straight.

Tank held me under one arm. Rosa held Marcellus by the wrist. We reached the lobby while security shouted into radios and guests tried to make their cars appear by promising the valets more money.

I turned toward the stairs again.

Tank put himself in front of me.

“She told me to get you out, nigga.”

“Move.”

“No.”

“Nigga, move.”

“You want to hate me, do it in the fucking car.”

He lifted me. Just picked me up like I weighed nothing and carried me through the doors. I cursed him until I couldn't get enough air. People stared. Let them. Nigga, if there had been a throne outside,

I would've smashed it to pieces because it didn't have her sitting beside it.

Rosa went with Marcellus to another car. Before she got in, she pushed one of the gala photographs through my open window.

“She gave me this,” she said.

The picture showed Shawna between me and Red. His hand against her arm. His ring under the lights. My hand at her waist like I thought holding her in a photograph meant the world couldn't take her anywhere.

Rosa's voice broke.

“She told me to keep one for when you two got married.”

I stared at it.

Then Tank drove.

We didn't get far before Marcellus called.

I put him on speaker. My fingers had gone sticky against the blue box.

“The stone,” he said. “Aiden. Listen carefully. The stone you have is the duplicate.”

Tank looked at me.

I opened the box beneath the dashboard light.

Blue looked back at me.

“You sure, nigga?”

“Nigga, I made it.”

I shut the lid.

Nigga. We had gone in with Shawna and come out with a fucking lie in velvet.

“Does Red know?” Tank asked.

Marcellus didn't answer right away.

“He expected you to take it.”

The road lights passed across the windshield. One. Another. Another. I counted them because if I stopped looking at something in front of me, I saw Red's arm across Shawna's chest.

Rosa took the phone.

“We still have the original order. And you have his papers.”

I looked at the folder against my leg. The corners were bent. On one page, a line of red ink lay beneath Valentino's name. On another was a list of payments tied to the old jewel transaction. Evidence of the life Red had built out of other people's bodies.

“I don't want his fucking papers.”

“I know.”

“I want her.”

“I know, Aiden.”

Tank drove faster. Not wild. Just like every second now had somebody's hand around its throat.

My phone lit up with an unknown number.

I answered before the first ring finished.

“Shawna?”

Red breathed into the line.

“I wondered how long it would take you to notice the gift.”

I put the phone against my ear so hard it hurt.

“Let me hear her.”

“Your friend has my three million. You have papers that belong in my desk. And somewhere, somebody is holding a very old note.”

“Let me hear her, nigga.”

A sound came through. Movement. A door. Then Shawna.

“Baby.”

I closed my eyes.

“I'm here.”

“I know.”

“I'm coming.”

“I know.”

Red took the phone away.

“The unfinished casino in the desert. Midnight. Bring the money. Bring the papers. Bring the original.”

I looked at the clock on the dashboard.

We had less than three hours.

“If you hurt her—”

“Then come before I get bored.”

The call ended.

Tank kept his eyes on the road.

For a while neither of us spoke. I held the photograph in one hand and the worthless blue box in the other. My white suit was ruined. My cheek still held the heat of Shawna's slap. Every place she had touched me that night felt like the only part of my body still alive.

"Take me to the money," I told Tank.

"Yeah."

"All of it."

"Yeah, nigga."

I put the photograph inside my jacket, over the cross.

I had walked into the Saint thinking I could steal a fortune and a future in one night. Now that nigga had my future locked in a room somewhere, and all the money in Vegas couldn't make the next red light change.

"Tank."

"What?"

"After we get her."

He glanced at me.

"Nigga, we are getting her."

I looked out at the city.

"After we get her, nigga, there isn't going to be enough desert left to hide what we do to him."

11. Everybody Bring Your Heart

At nine forty, I put my fist through the glass door of the house and cut myself for a woman who wasn't there to tell me to stop.

Tank caught my wrist before I could do it again.

“Aiden.”

I swung on him.

My nigga took it. His head went sideways, and his hand stayed around my wrist. There was blood on his lower lip. I hit him again, harder, and something in my wounded side pulled so sharp that my knees almost went.

“Nigga, let go.”

“No.”

“Nigga, you had the money.”

“Yeah.”

“This whole fucking time, nigga.”

“Yeah.”

I tried to drag him into the broken door with me. He turned his body and held me against the wall instead. Tank weighed enough to end an argument by falling asleep on the other person. I was hurting too bad to move him, and I hated that he knew it.

“Nigga, you let me walk in there thinking I knew what was mine.”

“I know.”

“You let him stand there and laugh at me.”

His face changed then. The shame had been sitting on him like sweat, but now something deeper came up. He looked past me into the house.

“I heard him,” Tank said. “I was standing right there.”

I shoved him once more. He let me go.

The front room still looked like a place where money went to get drunk. Two bottles of champagne sat in silver buckets. A woman I didn't know had left one red heel under the piano. Somebody had put a little pile of cocaine on a photograph of me and Shawna because there wasn't enough table in the whole fucking house. Her face was under it.

I swept everything onto the floor.

“Get these niggas out.”

There were only four men left inside, and all four were already moving.

“Everybody,” I said.

One of them had a woman's handbag slung over his shoulder. He looked down at it like he'd just discovered a child. He went back toward the hall, remembered my face, and left with it.

Tank shut the ruined door as well as it could be shut.

“You want me gone too?”

I looked at him. His jacket was torn. He'd lost a cuff link at the Saint. There was blood on his hands that wasn't mine or his, and he'd followed me out anyway.

“Get the money, nigga.”

He went upstairs.

I sat on the piano bench because it was the nearest thing and because my legs had started shaking. Shawna had been sitting there that afternoon. She'd played three notes, missed the fourth, and told me the piano was cheap. I'd offered to buy her another one. She'd asked if I was going to buy a different instrument every time she made a mistake.

I'd told her yes.

Nigga, I'd meant it. We would've had a fucking orchestra by Christmas.

Now her perfume was still in the room and Red had her.

I put my head down. For one ugly second I saw him kissing her. I saw the dance again, her hand on his shoulder, the way she'd leaned close because we'd agreed she had to. I'd said I could take it. I'd stood there dressed like a king and discovered I couldn't take shit.

The case upstairs hit something with a heavy thump.

“Don't you drop her money, nigga,” I shouted.

“I got it.”

“You been saying that.”

He came down carrying the money in two bags. No silver case. He'd saved the cash and left the case broken in the pool, just like he'd left the rest of us thinking it was all gone.

He opened the bags on the dining table.

Three million dollars filled the space between two candles Shawna had bought because she said the house smelled like men lying to each other.

Tank stood back.

“All of it.”

“You count it?”

“More than once, nigga.”

“That make you feel good, nigga?”

He shook his head.

I picked up a bundle and threw it at him. It hit his chest and broke against the floor.

“There’s your fucking tip.”

He watched the bills settle.

“Nigga, look at me.”

He did.

“What did you think was gonna happen, nigga?”

“Nigga, I thought you were gonna die.”

The room got quiet enough for me to hear the refrigerator.

Tank rubbed both hands over his head.

“That morning, before she drove off. You were bleeding all over the seat. She leaned through the open door and kept asking you to look at her. You kept saying the same shit about a house. Water. A room for singing. Nigga, you weren’t answering her half the time. I thought you were already gone.”

“So you went shopping, nigga.”

“So I went back, nigga.”

His voice rose. He looked ashamed of that too, but he kept going.

“T was there. The money was there. I looked at that nigga on the ground, and I thought about all the years I stood behind him. Every room. Every car. Every time somebody said his name wrong, I was the nigga who got up.”

“You loved that nigga.”

“Yeah.”

I stared at him.

“Say it again.”

“I loved him, nigga. You want me to lie about that too?”

His lip was bleeding down his chin. He didn't wipe it.

“You knew him one night. I knew him ten years. He was a piece of shit. I know. He'd give you something with one hand and keep the other around your neck. I know that too. But when I got there, I still wanted the nigga to get up.”

I looked down at the money.

“And when he didn't?”

“I took what was left.”

That was the first thing he'd said that didn't make me want to put him through a window.

It didn't make me forgive him either.

“That nigga Red got to you after.”

Tank nodded.

“Said he knew. Said the money bought him whatever he asked for.”

“And you believed that nigga.”

“For a while.”

“Until when, nigga?”

Tank looked straight at me.

“Until he put his hand on her and you stopped breathing.”

I felt the room tilt.

“Nigga, don't.”

“I'm telling you.”

“Don't tell me what I looked like.”

“You looked like you did in that car.”

I picked up a candle and threw it into the fireplace. The glass broke. Tank didn't move.

“I ain't dying in another fucking car.”

“Then let me drive, nigga.”

The front door moved behind us.

Rosa came in wearing a man's coat over her gala dress. One earring was gone. She had Marcellus by the arm. Tank brought the decoy's box in from the Mercedes and handed it to the old man, who took it like he was being given the head of somebody he used to know.

“Which one of you stupid niggas broke the door?” Rosa asked.

Nobody answered.

She saw my hand.

“Of course.”

She came straight to me, took my wrist, and looked at the cuts. Her fingers were shaking. She hadn't been shaking when she crossed the room.

“Where is she?”

“Red.”

“I know fucking Red. Where is that nigga?”

“He's bringing her to that casino in the desert. Midnight.”

“Then why are you bleeding on the furniture?”

I started to speak. Rosa gripped harder.

“You can be angry after she gets here, nigga. You can buy a mountain and fight the whole mountain. Right now I need you standing.”

“Don't talk to me like I'm a kid.”

“Then quit making me, nigga.”

Tank turned his face away. I looked at him.

“Something funny, nigga?”

“No.”

“Good.”

Rosa sat me down and went to get a towel. Marcellus stayed by the table. He looked at the money, then at me, then at the floor where the first bundle had come apart.

“Yours?” he asked.

“Hers.”

He nodded as though that settled a price we'd been fighting over.

When Rosa came back, she had my phone. It was vibrating in her hand.

Red had sent a picture.

Shawna sat in a white chair. Her dress was torn at the shoulder. Her hair covered one side of her face. Red stood behind her with his hand resting under her chin, his blue ring turned toward the camera.

I got up so fast the bench fell over.

Rosa caught my shirt.

“Aiden.”

“I'm gonna kill that nigga.”

“Look at her.”

“I am looking.”

“No. Her.”

I made myself stop staring at his hand.

Shawna was looking into the camera. Her mouth was swollen a little on one side. Her eyes were open and furious. She wasn't looking away from whoever would see it.

Under the picture, Red had written four words.

She remembers this room.

I called him.

He answered on the first ring.

“Nigga,” I said, “if you touch her again—”

“She's sitting right here.”

“Put her on, nigga.”

“Ask nice, nigga.”

I couldn't get air into my chest.

Rosa squeezed the back of my neck. I felt every finger.

“Please,” I said.

Red laughed softly.

Then Shawna was there.

“Aiden?”

“Baby.”

“Are you hurt?”

I closed my eyes.

“No.”

“Don't lie to me.”

“I'm here.”

There was a little noise on her end. Fabric moving. A breath that stopped too early.

“Tell Rosa I ruined her dress.”

Rosa pressed a fist against her mouth.

“She don't give a fuck about the dress, baby.”

“She does. Tell her I'll pay for it.”

Rosa took the phone out of my hand.

“You owe me a fucking earring too, bitch.”

Shawna laughed once.

That one little laugh made the whole room stand still.

Then Red came back.

“Midnight. Bring whatever you stole tonight. Bring my money. Come ready to apologize.”

I took the phone.

“You want me on my knees, nigga?”

“Now you're listening, nigga.”

“You keep her alive, you can see me any way you want.”

He hung up.

I stood there holding the dead call. Tank picked up the bench and set it behind me. I didn't sit.

Marcellus held out his hand.

“Let me see that photograph.”

I gave the old nigga the phone because I had run out of things to break that would make Red feel it.

The old man enlarged the picture.

His thumb stopped on the ring.

“There you are,” he whispered.

I looked up.

Marcellus had begun to smile, and there wasn't a happy thing in it.

12. What She Told Me After

Shawna told me what happened in that room later. She told it sitting beside me with her bare feet under my leg, stopping whenever she wanted water and starting again wherever it hurt. I asked her the same questions until she threatened to throw the glass at me. Some parts she could give me word for word. Some parts she wouldn't give anybody.

This is what she told me.

Red took her back through the Saint after we'd gone, with two men behind her and one hand around her arm. The party hadn't completely emptied. A few people were still holding drinks because nobody had personally told them the good time was dead.

She saw a woman by the elevators lift a phone.

“Get my good side,” Shawna said.

Red pulled her harder.

The woman lowered the phone.

“You always gotta do that?” he asked.

“Look good?”

“Make a fucking scene.”

“You dragged me out of one.”

He took her into a private room she knew. White chairs. White carpet. A huge painting of a horse coming out of the ocean. Red loved that painting. He'd once spent twenty minutes explaining the

horse to her while she tried to work out whether she could leave without him noticing.

Tonight the carpet had somebody else's blood on it.

One of the men had brought her purse from the office. Red took it from him and put it on the table. Then he shut the door and told the men to wait outside.

Shawna said that was when she first got scared enough to feel cold.

Not at the gunfire. Not at his hand on her arm. At the little click of the door and the fact that he wanted no one else to hear him talk.

“Sit,” he said.

She stayed standing.

“Shawna.”

“Give me a cigarette.”

He went to the table and took one from a silver box. He lit it before he handed it to her, like he was bringing her flowers.

“I could've killed that nigga,” he said.

She took the cigarette.

“Nigga, you tried.”

“Nigga ran.”

“My nigga's coming back.”

Red laughed.

“They always come back for the money.”

“Then put me outside and see.”

He didn't answer that. He poured a drink, missed the glass a little, and wiped the spill with his sleeve. Shawna noticed because Red never cleaned anything. He would wait for somebody to come across a whole room to pick up a thing beside his shoe.

He was angry enough to forget who he thought he was.

“You think that nigga loves you?”

She smoked.

“I asked you something.”

“I heard you.”

“That nigga loves winning. You're what he stole. Soon as you're just a woman in his house, watch what happens.”

She looked at the painting instead of him. The horse had its mouth open. She'd always thought it looked surprised to be swimming.

“He begged, you know,” Red said.

She kept looking at the horse.

“Dante. That nigga begged us to look after you.”

“Us.”

Red stopped with the bottle in his hand.

Shawna turned toward him.

“You were standing there?”

“I didn't say that.”

“Then who told you, nigga?”

He put the bottle down too carefully.

“Everybody knew what happened.”

“I didn't.”

He looked toward the door. She watched him do it. Shawna said she would've given anything to have the old letter and the order in her hand right then, to lay them in his lap and make him touch what he'd done. All she had was the watch. She turned it around her wrist.

“What did he call me?” she asked.

“What?”

“When he begged. What name did he use?”

“Your fucking name.”

“Which one?”

“Shawna, I don't remember every—”

“Dante called me Trouble.”

He stared at her.

“Miss Trouble if he was happy. Mrs. Trouble when I was mad at him. He'd come in and say, Mrs. Trouble, I fucked up, and I'd know I had to sit down before that nigga finished talking.”

She laughed, and that made Red angrier than anything she'd said. She couldn't help it. She was remembering Dante coming into their little apartment with a whole bumper in his hands. He'd taken it off the car he'd borrowed for their honeymoon. He'd brought the bumper upstairs because he thought she might be less mad if he hadn't left any of it behind.

“Nigga carried it like flowers,” she told me later. She laughed then too. I hated the dead nigga for making her laugh with something he'd done years before I met her, and I wanted to hear it again anyway.

In Red's room, she wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist.

“You don't know how he talked to me.”

“I know what he was.”

“Then talk about that. Talk about your dead nigga. You don't get to talk about mine.”

Red came close enough that she could smell the drink.

“You keep making him a saint.”

“No. I'm remembering my husband. That nigga stole money, lied badly, and left his socks in the bed. I loved him. You think telling me he was a bad man changes something?”

She touched the watch again.

“Tell me something I don't fucking know.”

“That nigga Dante said the same shit,” Red went on. “A house. A different life. Music. That nigga was gonna buy you a microphone and call himself a husband.”

Shawna turned back.

“That nigga was my husband.”

“I paid for the wedding.”

“You paid for the room.”

“I paid for everything.”

“Then you should've kept the receipts, nigga. Maybe the preacher would've married you.”

Red threw the glass.

It hit the wall beside the horse and broke. Shawna said she didn't move, which she was proud of until she told me why. Her legs had gone stiff. She couldn't move.

He came toward her.

“You used to know how to talk to me, nigga.”

“I used to need you to stop talking.”

He caught her face in one hand. That's where the picture came from. He called one of his men in and told him to take it while he held her there.

Shawna stared into the phone.

“He'll see you touching me,” she said.

“That's the point.”

“I know.”

The man took the picture and left. Red's ring dragged against the edge of her jaw when he let go.

She looked at it.

“You wearing it now, nigga?”

His hand closed.

“Wearing what, nigga?”

“All that money, and you still want somebody to notice.”

He put his hand in his pocket.

At the house, I didn't know any of this yet. Marcellus was still looking at the same photograph, holding my phone so close to his face I thought he might press his forehead through it.

"It's the stone," he said.

"You sure, nigga?"

"Yes."

"Nigga, we were sure at the party."

He looked at me over the top of the phone.

"You were."

I wanted to throw him through the rest of the door. I also wanted him to be right more than I'd wanted anything besides hearing her voice.

"Tell me, nigga," I said.

He set the decoy on the table. In that room it looked worth forty million dollars. It looked worth killing for. Red could've shown it to a king, and the king would've started moving money.

Marcellus looked at it like an old sin.

"He changed the setting on the original. Put dark stones around it. Made it look smaller by giving you other things to see."

"Can you tell that from a phone, nigga?"

"I can tell you he didn't do a good job."

His hands had steadied. For the first time that night, he was somewhere he'd spent more years than prison. He turned the picture toward the light.

“I saw the ring at the gala. Only from the side. I thought I recognized the shoulder of the mounting. Here.”

He touched the screen.

“The nigga kept that part.”

“Because it's gold?” Tank asked.

“Because that nigga's an idiot.”

Rosa let out a breath through her nose.

“Finally, some good fucking news.”

Marcellus showed us where the blue metal curved under the stone. Not a secret map. Not a number to somebody's money. A piece he'd made for Celeste, shaped by his own hand, carrying words he had wanted her to wear against her skin.

“He has my wife's name under his finger,” he said.

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Then I said, “We'll get it, nigga.”

He looked at me.

“Will we, nigga?”

“Yeah.”

“If that nigga says her or the diamond?”

“Her.”

I didn't wait to see how that felt to him.

“If that nigga says burn the letter?”

“I burn it.”

“If he says give him back the proof of what he did?”

“Then he gets it, nigga. You want me to make you a promise, I’ll make you one. I’m bringing her home. Everything else better find a way to come with us.”

Marcellus nodded. His mouth tightened once.

“Dante said something very much like that.”

I grabbed the edge of the table.

“Nigga, I’m not Dante.”

“I know.”

“Then stop putting that nigga between me and every fucking thing I do.”

Rosa said my name.

I shook my head.

“No. I love her. Right now. Me. I’m the nigga standing here bleeding. I’m the nigga going out there. You can remember him all you want, but when her phone rings, I want her to know who’s calling.”

My voice had gone loud enough to shake. I hated all three of them hearing it.

Marcellus took the papers we had brought out of the gala and laid them beside Celeste’s old letter. Rosa handed him the original order from Dante’s watch, still inside its envelope. He kept the different pages apart. One held a dead woman’s handwriting. The others held proof that Red had wanted another man dead. They’d

cost more nights than I could count, and I would have set them all on fire if it got Shawna through that door.

“Then give her something to answer,” he said.

He slid my phone back to me.

I opened her name.

The last message I'd sent before the gala was still there.

You look good as fuck.

She had sent back a picture of one eye, half her forehead, and her middle finger. She'd been trying to take a photograph of the whole dress and got mad at the phone.

I stared until the screen blurred.

Rosa stood beside me.

“She sent me six of those,” she said quietly. “Bitch got the bathroom ceiling in one.”

I wiped my face with the heel of my hand.

“Nigga,” I whispered, though I wasn't talking to anybody now.

I started typing.

I'm coming. Wear whatever you want.

Then I deleted the second sentence. She couldn't choose what she was wearing. She couldn't choose where she was sitting. Red would read it first, and I wanted to take his head off for being between us even inside a fucking phone.

I sent only the first two words.

At the Saint, Shawna said Red watched the message arrive. He held the phone where she could see it and smiled.

“Nigga thinks he's in a love song.”

“Then don't stand in the chorus.”

He took the phone away.

She asked for her purse. He laughed at that. She asked for water instead, and he brought it because he wanted to look like the kind of man who brought water.

“Tell me you were lying to that nigga,” he said.

She drank.

“About what?”

“All of it.”

“That's a lot of lying.”

“You lied to Valentino.”

She set the glass down.

“Yeah.”

“You lied to me.”

“Yeah.”

“Then tell me you lied to that nigga.”

He waited so hard that Shawna could see him believing her before she even opened her mouth. She said that was the ugliest thing in the room. He'd hurt her, trapped her, scared her, and still wanted her to make his heart feel better.

She almost gave him what he wanted. Not because it was true. Because she knew how to do it. She knew exactly how soft to

make her voice. She could've called him baby and watched his shoulders come down.

Instead she said, "I told Aiden I wasn't scared."

Red leaned closer.

"There you go."

"I told him I didn't think about Dante when we were together."

He smiled.

"And?"

"I told him I didn't like that stupid fucking cross."

"You see? You see what I'm saying?"

She looked straight at him.

"I told him I could live without him."

His smile went away.

She said his name then. Not mine. Red's. She wanted him to know he was the one hearing it.

"That was a lie."

He knocked the water out of her hand.

For a second she thought he was going to hit her again. He stood there breathing, staring at the wet front of her dress. Then he picked up his jacket.

"Get up."

"Where?"

"You wanna see your nigga so bad, let's go see him."

He opened her purse and took out the little silver pistol. He looked at it, then at her, and put it in his jacket.

“Taking this too,” he said.

He took her back into the hall. She left the cigarette burning in his silver box. She told me that part twice. Of everything he'd taken away from her that night, she wanted me to know he'd forgotten to make her put it out.

At ten thirty-seven, he sent me another message.

On our way. Don't disappoint her.

I looked around the room at Tank, Rosa, Marcellus, and the three million dollars that had already buried too many people.

“Call everybody,” I said.

Tank picked up his phone.

“Everybody, nigga?”

“Everybody who ever called me brother.”

13. Ten Toes, Thirty Engines

By eleven, the street outside the house was full of cars.

Niggas came in leather. Niggas came in silk. One came wearing the pajama shirt his woman had bought him, with a gold chain lying against the little white moons. He'd put on shoes and brought everything else he thought he needed. Another had a fresh haircut with shaving foam still behind his ear.

Nobody asked if I was serious.

They looked at the money and started asking who had to die.

I knew some of those niggas would have asked the same question in Red's house. I wasn't stupid. I was in love. People kept confusing the two, and tonight I had enough money to make them stop.

There were men there I'd drunk with, fought with, watched betray women who were still sending them plates from home. There were men there who'd carried T's coffin and called me boss before the flowers died. I wanted every rotten heart that would come when I called it.

The world could ask for better men in the morning.

I wanted mine now.

Tank stood at the dining table, putting the three million where everybody could see it. He didn't hide behind me. He waited until the room filled and then he spoke.

“This is the money from the motel.”

A few heads turned.

“I took it.”

One man beside the piano said, “Nigga, what?”

Tank kept his eyes on the room.

“I took all of it. I let Aiden think it was gone. Red knew. He tried to use it against him tonight.”

“Tried?” somebody asked.

“Tried.”

The man beside the piano looked at me.

“Nigga, and this nigga still breathing?”

Tank's jaw moved once.

I walked between them.

“Look at me when you say that, nigga.”

The man did.

“Tank's standing with me.”

“I'm just saying—”

“Say he stole it. He did. Say he's a lying motherfucker. He was. Say you're gonna touch him tonight, and you can find out how fucking fast I can forget your name.”

The room went still.

Tank looked at the back of my head. I could feel it.

The man by the piano lifted his hands.

“Your house, my nigga.”

“Yeah.”

I let that sit.

“My house. My money on the table. My girl with Red. If any of that bothers you, the door already fucking broke. You ain't gotta worry about hurting it.”

Nobody left.

Rosa stood by the staircase in the borrowed coat. She watched every face. Marcellus sat behind her with the decoy in its box and the papers inside his jacket. The old nigga looked tired enough to disappear if you let your eyes move too fast, but he hadn't asked to lie down.

I put my hand on the cash.

“Some of you came because you owe me. Some of you came because Red owes you. Some of you just heard there was gonna be money.”

One man in the back said, “All three, nigga.”

I looked at him.

He didn't apologize.

I nodded.

“Good.”

I started giving it away.

Not throwing it in the air. I wanted every nigga who touched it to look into my face while he did. I wanted him to feel the weight of it and know the woman we'd left behind had carried it out of a room full of killers before any of us had the nerve.

Stacks went into hands. Into coats. Into the pajama shirt, where the buttons strained so hard I thought the little moons were gonna fly off.

“Nigga, put that in a bag,” Tank told him.

“I’m good.”

“You look pregnant.”

“I’m good, nigga.”

I kept paying.

Some of them laughed. Some counted. One man held the money without doing either, and I remembered he’d been sitting in a hospital hallway two nights earlier with his head in his hands. Tonight he kissed the stack and tucked it inside his coat.

I didn’t ask which part of his life I’d just bought.

I had one woman to bring home, nigga. The whole city could put its heart on the fucking table.

When two million had left the bags, I stopped.

The last million stayed together. I pulled the bag shut and set it aside.

“That’s hers.”

Nobody argued.

Tank hadn’t taken anything. I picked up a share from the two million I’d already laid out and held it toward him.

He shook his head.

“No.”

“Take it, nigga.”

“Aiden.”

“You think I'm letting you go out there feeling poor and guilty, nigga? Pick one.”

His eyes flicked toward the men around us.

“Nigga, I don't want it.”

“Then spend it on somebody who does.”

I pushed the money against his chest until he took it.

He looked down at it. Then he put it on the table beside the million I was keeping for Shawna.

“For her, nigga,” he said.

I left it there. I wasn't counting love back into a fucking bag while everybody watched.

Rosa came down the stairs.

“And before all you niggas start singing about brotherhood, she's my friend.”

Nobody laughed. They knew her. Half the room stood up straighter when she came close.

“That means if you see her, you bring her. You don't stop to tell Red how hard you are. You don't start explaining a grudge from 2018. You bring her.”

The man with shaving foam behind his ear nodded.

“We got you, Rosa.”

“No, baby. You better have her.”

She turned to me.

I had held back part of the two million for her. I pushed it across the table.

She stared at it.

“What's this?”

“Yours.”

“For what?”

“Whatever you want.”

Her face went tight.

“You paying me to stay home?”

“I'm paying you because she loves you.”

Rosa looked up.

“Nigga, don't do that right now.”

“She gets out of that car tonight, I want somebody here she knew before every room had me in it.”

For the first time since she'd walked through the broken door, Rosa looked her age and her fear at once. Thirty-four years old, tired, one earring gone, holding the coat closed with a hand that had finally stopped shaking.

“You bring her,” she said.

I nodded.

She slapped my face.

Not hard enough to knock me down. Hard enough that the room went silent.

“With your mouth, Aiden.”

I swallowed.

“I’m bringing her.”

She kissed the same cheek.

“Then go, baby.”

I turned to the room.

“Any of you niggas here think Red owns Vegas?”

“Fuck Red,” somebody said.

“Anybody think that nigga owns my wife?”

Rosa made a sound behind me.

I turned halfway.

“What?”

“You ask her yet?”

“I’m going to.”

“Then quit inviting these niggas before me.”

The room broke open. Men laughed, slapped each other's shoulders, called out shit about weddings and suits and who wasn't allowed near an open bar. I let them. For a few seconds we had a future big enough to crowd a room.

Then I raised my hand.

“Niggas, listen to me.”

They quieted.

“I ain't asking you to die because I fell in love. I'm asking you to stand up with me because that nigga thinks he can take anything he sees. He took a man's wife. Took another man's diamond. Took Dante out to the desert and left him there. Tonight he took Shawna.”

I put my hand over the cross.

“He keeps telling everybody I'm wearing a dead nigga's jewelry. Fine. Let him look at it while I come get my girl.”

Tank stepped beside me.

“Ten toes,” he said.

The room answered.

“Down.”

He said it again, louder.

“Ten toes.”

“Down.”

Nigga, the windows shook. The broken front door moved in its frame. For one wild second I wanted the whole city to hear us, every penthouse and every parking lot and every woman waiting for a man to come back different.

I kissed the cross.

Then I went outside.

Tank drove the Mercedes.

I sat beside him because I still couldn't lean back without feeling T's bullet and because if anybody was going to meet Red first, it was going to be me.

Marcellus got into the back.

I looked over my shoulder.

"You sure about this, nigga?"

"No."

"Nigga, you can wait with Rosa."

"I have waited enough."

He shut the door before I could offer him anything else.

The decoy sat in its box beside him. The letters and the papers were in his coat. My phone lay faceup on my knee. Rosa stood in the driveway with the money she hadn't bothered to pick up still inside the house.

Tank had put the bag with Shawna's million and his returned share in the back. Red had asked for three million. He was getting what was left after I'd paid the niggas coming to take his kingdom.

She came to my window.

"Aiden."

I looked at her.

"She likes gardenias."

"What?"

"For the wedding, nigga. She likes gardenias. And she will lie and tell you roses because men always buy roses."

I gripped the door.

“Gardenias.”

“And don't let that old man give her away. I'll do it.”

Marcellus said, “I hadn't volunteered.”

Rosa pointed at him through the glass.

“Keep it that way.”

She stepped back.

The cars pulled out behind us until the street looked like the city had emptied its garages for a funeral and nobody had agreed whose.

Thirty engines. Maybe more by the time we reached the highway. Headlights filled both mirrors. My niggas had come wearing their money and their worst intentions, and I loved every last one of them for showing up.

Tank kept both hands on the wheel.

After a while he said, “You should let the doctor look at you after.”

“After.”

“I'm saying.”

“I heard you, nigga.”

He nodded.

The lights thinned outside the windows. Vegas went from towers to signs to little burning squares behind us. Ahead was black desert and the road laid through it.

“Tank.”

“Yeah.”

“When you came back for the money. Did he look like himself?”

He knew who I meant.

He drove another few seconds before he answered.

“No.”

I looked down at the cross.

“Good.”

Tank's hands tightened.

“You don't gotta say that, nigga.”

“I know.”

He didn't answer. I watched the side of his face and remembered him standing behind T in the parking lot, as big as a wall, waiting for somebody else to decide what he'd do.

“I'm glad you here, nigga.”

His jaw moved.

“Yeah.”

“Don't make me say it twice.”

“I heard you.”

In the back, Marcellus turned the decoy's box between his hands.

“She wore blue the last time I took her dancing,” he said.

Neither of us asked who.

“Celeste. I was late. She was furious. By the time I got there, she'd danced with three other men.”

“Three?” I said.

“She counted them for me.”

Tank glanced in the mirror.

“You do something to those niggas?”

“I asked for the fourth dance, nigga.”

I looked out at the dark.

“Could've been me, nigga.”

“It wasn't.”

He closed the box and rested his head against the seat.

We drove the rest of that stretch without talking.

At eleven fifty-four, Red called.

I put him on speaker.

“You coming?” he asked.

“You hear the cars, nigga?”

“I told you to come ready to apologize.”

“I am.”

Tank looked at me.

“I told her I'd never let you put your hands on her again. Got a lot to apologize for.”

Red breathed into the phone.

“You think all those niggas love you?”

“Enough to leave the house, nigga.”

“That's money.”

“Then you should've paid better, nigga.”

He went quiet.

I heard Shawna in the background. I couldn't make out the words, only her voice and the way he moved the phone away from her.

“Let me talk to her.”

“You'll see her soon.”

“Nigga, let me—”

He hung up.

I gripped the phone so hard Tank reached over and took it before I broke that too.

“We're here, my nigga,” he said.

The casino rose out of the desert half finished, huge and white under lights that made the empty windows look blacker. Red had built columns tall enough for a king and stopped before anybody could decide what kingdom he thought he had. Plastic sheeting moved behind the glass. A fountain outside had never held water.

Cars waited across the entrance. Men stood between them. Above the front doors, a balcony ran along the second floor beneath an unfinished crown of stone.

There she was.

Shawna stood at the railing in Rosa's ruined dress. Her hair blew across her face. Even from the car I could see Dante's watch on her wrist.

Red stood beside her.

He lifted the hand with the ring and waved like he'd invited us for dinner.

Behind me, engine after engine went quiet. My niggas were here.

I opened my door.

My side hurt. My hand hurt. Everything in me that knew how to be scared was awake and screaming.

I put both feet on the ground anyway.

Shawna saw me.

She stepped toward the railing before Red caught her arm.

“Aiden!”

I looked straight up at her.

“I'm here, baby.”

The clock on my phone turned eleven fifty-nine.

14. The Last King of Vegas

Red had her standing beneath a chandelier that had never been turned on. Nigga hadn't even finished building the place where he wanted to die.

Everything around them was unfinished. Marble on one wall, naked concrete on the next. A staircase big enough for a king coming down into a floor covered with building dust. The place was supposed to be Red's next casino. He had brought my woman here to make me watch him take my whole life away before the fucking doors even opened.

I stepped out of the Mercedes.

Tank got out beside me. Behind us, the convoy stretched across the parking lot, headlights burning through the dust. Niggas I had known for years. Niggas who had started calling me boss eleven days ago. Blue on their wrists, blue at their throats, guns in their hands. Nobody was smiling, my nigga. Nobody had come to make peace.

I looked up at Shawna.

Her dress was torn at one shoulder. Somebody had hurt her mouth. She held her chin high, but I could see her looking for me in the dark.

I raised my hand.

She saw it.

That was all I needed. That was the whole motherfucking world right there, nigga. Every fucking dollar I'd ever touch could burn before I'd leave her up there.

Red stepped into view beside her, wearing white from his shoes to the collar of his shirt. The blue stone on his right hand flashed when he put that hand on her shoulder.

Forty million dollars. Marcellus's life. Celeste's last letter. Dante's blood. All that shit sitting on a finger like it had always belonged to him.

"Aiden," he called down. "You brought everybody, nigga."

"I told them there was a dead nigga here."

Tank looked at me, and I could feel what he wanted to say. Don't let this nigga make you move before you think. Don't give him another piece of you because you're mad.

But I was past mad. I had gone through mad on the highway. Whatever was in me now had no place left to go except straight up those stairs.

"Come inside, nigga," Red said. "Just you and Tank."

I started walking.

Tank caught my sleeve.

"Nigga."

I stopped.

"We get her and we leave, my nigga."

"We get her," I said.

He looked at me for another second. Then he let go.

Inside, Red's niggas stood between roulette tables covered in plastic. I could see guns beneath jackets. I could see the ones who weren't bothering to hide them. There must've been thirty motherfuckers waiting for us in that room, and I walked between them with my head up because Shawna was watching.

Thirty niggas. I counted them because I wanted to know how many men I'd tell her I walked through when we got home. We were going home. I had already decided that shit in the car.

Red came down the staircase with Shawna beside him. He held her elbow. Every time his fingers tightened, I wanted to tear that arm out of his fucking jacket.

"Let her walk, nigga," I said.

"She is walking."

"Let her walk to me, nigga."

He stopped halfway down.

"You haven't paid for anything yet, nigga."

Tank stepped closer to me.

"We got your money, nigga."

Red laughed.

"My nigga, you think this is about the three million now?"

"That's what you been asking for, nigga."

"I asked for respect, nigga. The money was the easy part."

He looked at me.

"Tell me something, Aiden. How much did she tell you about that first night?"

Shawna closed her eyes.

I didn't look away from him.

"Enough, nigga."

"Did she tell you she was supposed to get in a car with whoever T sent? Could've been you. Could've been Tank. Could've been any nigga with a pulse and a place to hide the money."

"Don't," Shawna said.

Red leaned close to her.

"We're being honest. That's what lovers want, isn't it?"

I could hear Tank breathing beside me.

Red lifted Shawna's wrist. Dante's watch hung loose against her skin.

"Look at that, nigga. You got a palace, cars, an army. You got motherfuckers out here willing to die because they think you're the next big thing. And she still wears a dead man's watch."

Something opened up inside me.

It wasn't the wound.

I had looked at that watch every morning. At the breakfast table. In bed. When she put her hand on my face. I had pretended it didn't bother me because I thought a man with everything wasn't supposed to be jealous of somebody in the ground.

But I was, nigga. I was jealous enough to hate myself for it.

"Tell him," Red said to her. "Tell him whose chain made you go over there."

She looked at me.

"Dante's."

I felt Tank turn toward me.

I kept my eyes on her.

"First time I kissed you," she said, "I was looking at his cross. I wanted something of him back. I didn't know what I was doing."

Red smiled.

Nigga thought he had me. He was watching my hand, waiting for the gun to sag, waiting for me to look at her the way he wanted. He'd have paid to see me hate her.

"And now?" I asked.

Shawna swallowed. There was blood at the corner of her mouth.

"Now I'm looking at you."

Red's smile went away.

"Don't give that nigga that shit."

"I'm looking at you, Aiden."

I nodded once.

"Then keep looking, baby."

Red hit her. Nigga hit her right in front of me.

I moved before I thought about it.

Tank grabbed my arm, but I was already pulling free. Guns came up all around the room. I heard men shouting my name. I heard Red tell them not to fire yet.

Shawna caught the banister instead of falling. She lifted her head slowly, and the look she gave him was the same look she must've given Valentino in that car.

Red saw it too.

He put his pistol under her jaw.

Everything stopped.

"One more step, nigga," he said.

I stood at the foot of the stairs.

My heart was beating so hard it hurt the place where T had shot me.

"You win, nigga," I said.

Tank stared at me.

"Aiden."

"Let her come down. You want the west side, take it. You want the house, take it. My money. My name. Whatever the fuck you want."

Red watched my face.

I meant it, my nigga. I had been telling everybody I was a king, but I would've walked out of that room with nothing but her hand in mine. We could sleep in the fucking car. Let the nigga have the house.

"You hear that?" he asked Shawna. "He'll give me everything."

"Then take it and let me go."

He shook his head.

"Dante offered me everything too."

The words hung between us.

Red looked down at the ring on his hand.

"Your husband thought having a brother made him untouchable.

You think having these niggas outside makes you untouchable.

Everybody thinks there's one nigga who won't sell them."

He looked at Tank.

"How much you take out of that pool again?"

Tank's face hardened.

"I gave it back."

"After I told him you had it."

"I gave it back."

Red laughed at him.

"Come stand over here, Tank. You don't gotta die for a nigga you met eleven days ago."

Tank looked at me.

I didn't say anything. I had already asked him for more than I had any right to ask. I wasn't going to beg him now with Red watching.

Tank put his hand on my shoulder.

Right over the place where Big T had put his hand on the first night.

"That's my brother, nigga," he said.

Red shot him.

Tank hit me as he went down. His weight knocked me sideways. The first burst of gunfire tore through the room before his body reached the floor.

I fired up the stairs.

Red pulled Shawna against him and went backward through the doorway at the top. I tried to follow him with the gun, but there was too much of her in front of him. Too much of my whole fucking life between me and the man I wanted dead.

Tank grabbed my ankle.

"Go," he said.

Blood was coming through his shirt below the shoulder.

"Nigga, go get her."

The men outside hit the doors.

Glass came down all over the entrance. I heard our people shouting. I saw blue rags moving between the tables. Somebody went down across a roulette wheel. Somebody else fell through the plastic over the bar. Guns flashed in the dark like the whole casino had caught fire from the inside.

I went up the stairs, nigga. One hand on the rail, one on the gun, and Tank's voice still in my ears.

I don't remember every shot I fired. I remember a nigga in a brown jacket coming around the landing. I remember hitting the wall beside his head, then hitting him. I remember the pain in my side

getting hot and wet. I remember thinking I had promised her a room for her music, and I wasn't going to let some motherfucker turn that promise into another photograph she carried around.

At the top, the hallway split around an unfinished fountain.

Red's white jacket disappeared through a set of doors at the far end.

I followed.

The room beyond was open to the desert. They hadn't put the glass in yet. A balcony ran along the edge, looking down over the lights of our cars.

Red had Shawna against the railing.

Her little silver pistol fell out of his jacket as he hauled her against the railing. It struck the floor beside his shoe.

"Drop it, nigga," he told me.

I stopped in the doorway.

"Drop it or she goes over, nigga."

There was nothing beneath the balcony but concrete and steel.

Shawna looked at me. Her eyes were wide. She was scared now. Really scared. No black dress, no diamonds, no cold story about killing Valentino could hide that from me.

"Put her down, nigga," I said.

"Put the gun down, nigga."

I lowered it.

Set it on the floor.

Red watched me do it.

Then he smiled.

"That's how your husband died, Shawna. That's how Dante went down. Hands open. Begging. T couldn't even look at him."

"He wasn't begging for himself," she said.

Red's arm tightened.

"What?"

"You said he wanted somebody to take care of me."

"Shut the fuck up."

"He wasn't begging for himself."

She drove her head backward into his face.

He staggered. His gun went off into the empty sky. Shawna dropped to the floor, reached for her little silver pistol, and came up firing.

The first shot hit his leg.

The second hit him in the chest.

Red fell against the railing, one hand still reaching toward her.

"Dante," she said.

Just his name.

She tried to raise it again. Her hand was shaking so badly the barrel fell below his chest.

Red was still standing.

He lifted his pistol.

I had mine back in my hand by then.

I put him down, my nigga.

I fired until his gun fell out of his hand. Until his knees hit the balcony. Until the nigga who had taken years from her life was on the ground looking up at a sky he wasn't ever going to own.

Then I went to her.

She was on her knees, still holding the silver gun.

"Baby."

She didn't look up.

"Shawna."

Her hand wouldn't open.

I put mine around it.

"It's done."

She shook her head.

I wanted her to say my name. Nigga, I wanted it so bad I could hardly breathe. She kept saying Dante's. I put my gun down beside hers and got both arms around her.

I held her on the floor while she cried for Dante.

And I held her tighter because I was the one who was there.

Downstairs, somebody shouted that Red was dead.

Then somebody shouted my name.

More voices picked it up. Through the hall. Across the casino. Out into the parking lot where all those headlights were still burning.

Aiden.

Aiden.

My nigga, I had blood in both shoes and her face against my neck, and they were calling me the king of Vegas.

I believed them, nigga.

Before we left, I took Blue Mercy off Red's hand. He'd stopped reaching for anything by then. Forty million dollars in my fist, my nigga, and I closed it so hard the setting cut my palm.

Tank was alive when we got back downstairs.

Rosa had come after us with Dr. Vega. She told me later she'd sat in the house watching the clock until she couldn't fucking stand it, then gone to get the doctor and driven out behind the convoy. They came through the doors after the shooting stopped. Vega was bent over a wounded man near the entrance when I saw her.

Tank lay beside the roulette table with Rosa holding a folded tablecloth against him. Her dress was covered in blood. She looked at me like she was ready to fight God if he tried to take another person out of that room.

"Where the fuck you been, nigga?"

"With her."

She looked past me. Saw Shawna. Her face broke, and she had to press her mouth shut before she could talk again.

"Come here, baby."

Shawna went down beside her.

Tank opened his eyes when I knelt.

"You got her, my nigga?"

"Yeah."

"Red?"

"Dead."

He tried to smile. It hurt him.

"You better pay my fucking hospital bill, nigga."

I took his hand.

"Every penny, nigga."

"And the car."

"What car?"

"I want one."

"Nigga, you can have a hundred fucking cars."

He shut his eyes again.

"Black ones."

I held on until the doctor came.

I kept my hand around his. The last nigga who called me family had put a bullet in me before the night was over. Tank had taken one instead. Every time a voice came through the door, I looked up expecting somebody to tell me what else I could pay to keep him breathing.

I wasn't letting him wake up alone.

Marcellus came into the casino after the shooting stopped.

He walked through the broken glass slowly. His shoes were old and polished. He looked at the walls, the marble, the great staircase Red had built with other people's lives.

Then he looked at me.

I put the ring in his hand.

Blue Mercy flashed under the work lights.

For a long time he didn't speak.

His thumb moved across the setting. Red had put her stone in his own ring. Marcellus turned it in his hand, held it beneath the light, and closed his eyes.

Then he took Celeste's letter out of his coat. He laid the ring against the paper and bent his head over both of them.

I let him take all the time he needed.

"What are you going to do?" I asked.

He closed his hand around the ring.

"Take my wife home."

I nodded.

Forty million dollars, my nigga. I put forty million dollars in an old man's hand and watched him walk away because the woman I loved had just killed a man while saying another man's name, and for the first time that night I understood why some things couldn't be bought back.

Everything else in that casino was mine.

I made sure every nigga understood that too.

15. Ten Toes Down Forever

They put Tank in a private room with a view of the mountains.

I paid for the room next door for Rosa because she wouldn't leave him. She said she was there for Shawna. Tank said Rosa had called him handsome while she was keeping him alive, and he wanted witnesses.

She told him he was full of shit.

He smiled at her anyway. Nigga was hooked. I could've told him that from the doorway.

My nigga, I had seen that man face down in the dirt, seen him take punches that would've broken somebody else's neck, seen him stand beside T like nothing in the world could ever make him move. I hadn't ever seen him nervous before a woman walked into a room.

I bought him a black Cadillac.

Then I bought him another one because he called me from the hospital and said the first picture didn't do the color justice.

"Nigga, you buying me a car or showing me a car?" he asked.

"Look out your fucking window."

I heard Rosa open the blinds. Heard that big nigga start laughing. He had to stop because it hurt him. Then he started again.

Nigga had almost died for me. I would've painted the whole fucking city black if he'd asked.

I went back to the house with Shawna three days after Red died.

The lake was quiet. There were flowers at the gate, flowers on the stairs, flowers in the bedroom. Niggas I'd never met sent bottles and watches. Women sent silk, perfume, diamonds. Somebody sent a white horse with a blue ribbon tied into its mane.

I had the horse taken around to the back where she could see it from the balcony.

Shawna stood at the bedroom window and looked down at it.

"You buy that?"

"Somebody sent it."

"Why?"

"Because they know who you are."

She watched it walking beside the water.

"I don't know how to ride."

"Then we'll learn."

She turned toward me.

For a second, I thought she was going to cry again.

Then she laughed.

I had missed that sound so bad, nigga. I had been hearing gunfire in my sleep, hearing T say son, hearing Red tell me she'd have got in the car with anybody. I had started thinking that was all the world had left to say to me.

Then she laughed and came across the room and kissed me.

I picked her up. She wrapped her arms around my neck, and I carried her away from the window while the sun went down

behind the mountains. My side hurt. I didn't put her down. Nigga, I'd carried worse for men who loved me less.

Later, we lay awake listening to the water.

Her watch rested on the nightstand.

I looked at it for a while.

She saw me looking.

"You want me to take it off?"

I didn't answer right away.

I wanted everything, my nigga. Her mornings. Her nights. The way she turned her head when somebody said my name. I wanted to be the man she thought of when a song came on. I wanted to reach back three years and be the one carrying that cake into the club. I wanted to put myself in every photograph that had ever made her happy.

I couldn't, nigga.

And all the money in Vegas couldn't help me with that. I'd bought half a fucking city, my nigga, and I couldn't buy one night three years ago.

"No," I said.

She rested her head on my chest.

"Sometimes I miss him when I'm happy."

I looked at the ceiling.

"With me?"

"Yeah."

That hurt. I'm not going to lie to you, nigga. That shit went straight through me.

She lifted her head.

"Because I wish he knew I wasn't hurting all the time anymore."

I looked at her then.

She touched the cross against my chest.

"I wish he knew somebody stayed."

I took her hand and held it there.

Neither of us said anything for a long time.

Then I asked her to marry me. Right there, my nigga. No shirt, no ring, her dead husband's watch where both of us could see it.

She sat up.

"Aiden."

"I mean it."

"You just bought me a house."

"I'll buy you another one."

"That's not what I'm saying."

"Then tell me what you're saying."

She looked at me with tears in her eyes.

"You can't fix every bad thing that ever happened to me."

"I know."

"You gonna be mad when you find that out for real?"

I sat up beside her.

"I'm gonna be mad about a lot of shit, baby. I'm a fucked-up man. You know that."

She nodded.

"I'm asking you to marry me, baby. Bring the watch. Bring the pictures. Bring every fucking thing you can't leave behind. Just come with me."

She put her hand over my mouth.

Then she started laughing and crying at the same time.

"Yes," she said.

I kissed her palm.

"Say it again."

"Yes, nigga. I'll marry you."

I had fifty niggas outside that house ready to die for me and more money than I could count in one room, and I swear to you none of it had ever made me feel like that one word.

We got married beside the lake.

Three weeks after I walked into the Saint, my nigga. The flowers cost more than every rent payment I'd ever made put together. Shawna came toward me in a white dress while a woman sang the song she used to sing in her mother's kitchen.

Blue roses and the gardenias I had promised her covered the aisle.

There were diamonds at her throat. Dante's watch on her wrist.

I wore the cross.

Tank stood beside me in a black suit with his arm still healing under the jacket. Rosa sat in the front row wearing a blue dress and trying not to look at him. He looked at her enough for both of them.

Every table had a bottle of Hennessy on it. Every nigga at the gate had a gun. Behind the flowers, my people watched the road while men from other cities came to shake my hand and find out whether the stories were true.

Nigga, they were true enough that none of them tried me.

I paid the singer more than she asked. Then I paid her band. Then I bought the place where she'd been playing because Shawna said the owner had treated her like shit once, years ago, when she was trying to get an audition.

I didn't bring him to the wedding.

I made that nigga listen to it from the parking lot.

Shawna reached me and put her hands in mine.

For a moment I forgot everybody else was there.

The preacher asked me if I would love her in sickness and in health.

I looked at the scar above her eyebrow. At the mark still fading on her mouth. At the wrist she had held against my bleeding side when all I had to give her was a promise about a house near the water.

"I will."

He asked her the same.

"I will."

That's how it happened, my nigga. Her hand was shaking in mine. Tank kept wiping his face with the sleeve on his good arm. Rosa was crying into a napkin she'd stolen off his table. My girl said yes in front of the whole fucking city.

I kissed my wife while the band played and my people shouted my name.

Then we went inside and got so drunk the sun came up before anybody remembered there had been a schedule.

There was cocaine in the upstairs bathroom, cash changing hands on the terrace, hookers dancing with men who had brought other women to the wedding. Somebody drove a convertible onto the lawn. Tank fell asleep with his good arm around Rosa, and she threatened to kill the first motherfucker who took a picture.

I bought every picture the next morning.

I kept one. Nigga looks at it now and swears he was awake. Rosa has the same picture by her bed.

People tell this story like everything ended when Red hit the ground.

It didn't, nigga.

The calls kept coming. The money kept coming. The west side still needed a boss on Monday. A man in another city still thought Red dying meant he could take what Red used to sell. Somebody still owed somebody, and somebody's brother still wanted blood.

I didn't become a good man because I put a ring on Shawna's finger.

I was still the nigga who walked into a hotel with blood on his collar and told another man's people the girl was coming with him. I still had a temper. Still had a gun. Still woke up some nights with my hand on the place T had shot me.

And I still wanted everything.

But now I knew who I was bringing it home to, my nigga.

One night, months later, I came back from handling business and found Shawna in the room we'd made for her music.

She had all the lights off except the little lamp beside the piano. There were papers on the floor. A half-finished drink on the windowsill. She was singing something I hadn't heard before.

I stood in the doorway and listened.

When she finished, she turned around.

"How long you been there?"

"Long enough."

"You like it?"

"Yeah."

"You always say that."

"I always mean it."

She held out her hand.

I went to her.

Outside, there were niggas guarding the gates and a city waiting for me to make the next decision. In that room, she pulled me down beside her and put my hand against her heart.

"Stay a minute," she said.

I stayed all night, my nigga.

Aight, my nigga. Now you know.

You know about the money in the pool. You know about the blood in the car. You know why I wear a dead man's cross and why my wife still wears his watch. You know which nigga called me son and tried to kill me, and which nigga took a bullet before he'd let me stand alone.

Don't let anybody tell you I came out of that desert clean, nigga. I came out alive. I came out with Shawna's hand in mine and Tank bleeding in the back of an ambulance, and I made the whole fucking city learn our names.

My nigga, I gave away the most expensive diamond I ever held. Then I took everything the man wearing it thought he was going to leave behind. That's what happened. That's my money in the walls of that house. That's my name on the cars. That's my wife singing with the window open when the lake goes black at night.

And when she wakes up crying, nigga, I'm there. When Tank calls me at three in the morning, nigga, I answer. When some motherfucker thinks the years made me soft, nigga, I let him get close enough to see the scar.

You can call that love. You can call that crazy. Call it whatever the fuck you want, my nigga. I was crazy before she loved me. I had blood on me before she touched me. She didn't make me dangerous. She gave all that danger somewhere to come home.

I remember Dante, nigga. I never met him, but I remember him every time that gold cross hits my chest. I remember T, nigga. I wish I could remember him without the gun. I remember Red, nigga. I remember what he looked like when he found out there was something in that room he couldn't buy.

And I remember her in the Mercedes, my nigga. One hand on the wheel. One hand trying to keep my life inside me. She could've left me. She could've taken what she could carry and gone. But she stayed, nigga. My girl stayed.

So I stayed too, nigga.

Ten toes down, nigga. In the club. In the desert. In that hospital hallway waiting for Tank to open his eyes. Ten toes down, nigga, when the money came. Ten toes down, nigga, when the money wasn't worth a fucking thing.

And if another man comes through that gate thinking he's going to make her cry like that again, my nigga, he better bring every goddamn prayer he knows.

Because I'm home now, nigga.

Aiden.

Ten toes down. Forever, my nigga.